A DISSERTATION

Governing Beyond the Grave

Mortmain Sovereignty, the Docking Aporia, and the Ethics of Inheritance in BioWare's Mass Effect *Trilogy*



SPECULATIVE PHILOSOPHY · POLITICAL THEOLOGY · GAME STUDIES

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that BioWare's *Mass Effect* trilogy (2007–2012), developed under the direction of Casey Hudson, constitutes the most sustained speculative inquiry in early twenty-first-century popular culture into the problem of inheritance: the question of how the living ought to stand toward what the dead have built, archived, and bequeathed. Against the three frames that have dominated the trilogy's reception—first contact, the rebellion of artificial intelligence, and the architecture of moral choice—it reconstructs the work's cosmology, political ontology, ethics, and eschatology as a single argument organised around a figure here termed *mortmain sovereignty*: rule exercised by the archived and aggregated dead over the living through inherited infrastructure. The Reapers are read neither as Berserkers nor as Borg but as a literalised Hobbesian body politic, each one, in Sovereign's self-description, a "nation" compounded from a harvested species, whose fifty-millennial harvest fuses Marx's dead labour, Freud's repetition compulsion, Derrida's archive fever, Schmitt's *katechon*, and the perverse instantiation of contemporary alignment theory into one political-theological machine. Where Foucault's biopolitics names power over life and Mbembe's necropolitics the subjugation of life to the power of death, mortmain sovereignty names a third modality that the trilogy renders with unusual precision: the government of the living *by* the dead.

Four further coinages articulate the argument. *Crucible solidarity* names the counter-principle the trilogy assembles across narrative, procedure, and reception: a trans-cyclical partnership among the dead, the living, and the unborn, which is to say Burke's intergenerational contract purged of its conservative closure by Benjaminian remembrance, Arendtian natality, and Freudian mourning. The *docking aporia* names the trilogy's deepest structural proposition, that emancipation from the dead hand can be executed only through the dead hand's own apparatus, since the Crucible, designed across cycles, functions only when joined to the Citadel the Reapers built. The *sacrificial remainder* names the economy of loss that every resolution in the trilogy produces, and grounds a reading of its ethics not as the avoidance of sacrifice, which the work treats as impossible, but as the refusal to disavow it: a distinction between mournful agency and melancholic sovereignty. The *ludic testament* names the trilogy's formal innovation, the transmission of player decisions across three games and five years, which makes the player the heir and executor of a prior self.

Reading the four endings (Destroy, Control, Synthesis, and the Refusal added by the 2012 *Extended Cut*) as four political-theological postures toward the dead hand—to smash it,

to seize it, to sublate it, or to abstain from it—the dissertation argues that none escapes the docking aporia, and that this failure is the trilogy's truth rather than its defect. The ending controversy of 2012 is then reinterpreted as the same aporia enacted at the level of authorship: the collision of the players' archived history with the authors' testamentary code, a scene in which the author proves not dead, as Barthes proposed, but undead.

Methodologically, the study places the trilogy in constellation with its philosophical originators, from Aristotle, Augustine, and Hobbes through Kant, Hegel, Marx, and Nietzsche to Heidegger, Benjamin, Arendt, Levinas, Foucault, Derrida, and Haraway, and with a comparative corpus of speculative fiction, film, and games extending from Shelley, Wells, Čapek, and Stapledon through Asimov, Le Guin, Octavia E. Butler, Lem, Simmons, Reynolds, and Liu Cixin to *Deus Ex*, *Babylon 5*, *Battlestar Galactica*, *Neon Genesis Evangelion*, *NieR: Automata*, and *Outer Wilds*. It distinguishes documented provenance from generic inheritance and structural homology, and it reads procedure—the Paragon/Renegade economy, the loyalty system, the War Assets ledger, the save-file import—as argument in its own right. It concludes that the trilogy speaks most forcefully where it is least consoling: to the inheritance crises of the present, from the alignment of artificial intelligence and the lock-in of planetary infrastructure to the obligations the living owe the unborn.

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The Problem of the Dead Hand

> *The vanity and presumption of governing beyond the grave is the most ridiculous and insolent of all tyrannies.*
>
> — Thomas Paine, *Rights of Man* (1791)

> *Die Tradition aller toten Geschlechter lastet wie ein Alp auf dem Gehirne der Lebenden. [The tradition of all dead generations weighs like a nightmare on the brain of the living.]*
>
> — Karl Marx, *Der achtzehnte Brumaire des Louis Bonaparte* (1852)

I. The Argument

Every civilisation in the *Mass Effect* galaxy lives in a house it did not build. The mass relays that make interstellar society possible, the Citadel that houses its government, the element-zero physics on which its ships, weapons, and biotic bodies depend, and the Prothean ruins from which its younger species vaulted into space are disclosed, across three games, to be a bequest: an estate left by the dead and administered on behalf of a power that returns every fifty thousand years to collect. The trilogy's decisive revelation is therefore not that the galaxy is menaced by machines, a premise the genre had exhausted long before 2007, but that the galaxy is *inherited*, and that the terms of the inheritance are the instrument of its destruction. Vigil, the Prothean virtual intelligence that Commander Shepard encounters on Ilos at the climax of the first game, delivers the disclosure in the idiom of an executor reading a will: the relays and the Citadel were left so that each new cycle of civilisation would develop along predictable lines, settle where it was expected to settle, and gather its government at the one place from which it could be decapitated (ME1, "Ilos"). The legacy is the trap; the gift is the lure; the heirs are the harvest.

This dissertation contends that *Mass Effect* is, at bottom, a probate drama staged at galactic scale: a contest over the will of the dead. Its antagonists are the most literal embodiment that popular culture has produced of what the common law calls *mortmain*, the "dead hand" by which a corporate body that cannot die holds property in perpetuity and thereby

binds the living to the dispositions of the past. The English Statute of Mortmain of 1279 forbade lands to pass into such hands without royal licence; the Rule against Perpetuities, traceable to the Duke of Norfolk's Case of 1682, limited the span over which a testator could dictate the future; Jefferson, writing to Madison in September 1789, insisted that the earth belongs in usufruct to the living and that the dead have neither powers nor rights over it. Burke replied, in effect, the following year: society is a partnership not only among the living but among the living, the dead, and those who are yet to be born. Paine answered Burke in 1791 with the sentence that serves as this introduction's first epigraph. The Reapers, I shall argue, are Paine's nightmare given hulls: a sovereignty that governs beyond the grave because it *is* the grave, a perpetual corporation compounded from the harvested populations of prior cycles, holding the galaxy's infrastructure in a perpetuity of fifty millennia. The trilogy's answer, assembled slowly and never completed, is Burke's partnership redeemed: an alliance of the dead, the living, and the unborn that takes the form of a machine designed across cycles and carried, at the last, to the very structure built to prevent it.

The argument proceeds through five propositions. First, the trilogy figures a distinctive modality of power, here called mortmain sovereignty, which is irreducible to the sovereign right to kill, to the biopolitical management of life (Foucault 1976; 1997), or to the necropolitical subjugation of life to death (Mbembe 2003; 2019): it is the government of the living *by* the dead, exercised through archives and infrastructures rather than through laws or camps. Second, the trilogy's emancipatory project is structured by an aporia, the *docking aporia*, according to which liberation from the dead hand can be executed only by means of the dead hand's own apparatus, so that every act of emancipation is also an act of inheritance. Third, the trilogy's ethics is organised not around the avoidance of sacrifice, which it treats as structurally impossible, but around the acknowledgement of a *sacrificial remainder*: what distinguishes Shepard from the Catalyst is not that one sacrifices and the other does not, but that the one mourns and the other disavows. Fourth, the trilogy's formal innovation, the importation of player decisions across three games and five years, constitutes a *ludic testament* in which the player becomes the heir of a prior self, so that the work's theme is enacted in the very temporality of its play. Fifth, the controversy that greeted the trilogy's conclusion in 2012 was the docking aporia reproduced at the level of authorship, a scene in which the players' archived history collided with the authors' testamentary code, and in which the author proved not dead but undead.

Taken together, these propositions yield the thesis of the work: that *Mass Effect* is a speculative philosophy of inheritance whose deepest claim is that no clean inheritance is possible, that every bequest is at once partnership and tyranny, and that the living can be released from the dead hand only by receiving it, naming what it costs, and handing it on. The trilogy calls the instrument of that release the Crucible. I call the ethic it implies *crucible solidarity*.

II. Corpus, Conditions, and Provenance

The primary corpus comprises the three games of the original trilogy, their downloadable content, the in-game Codex (whose encyclopaedic entries function as the fiction's scholarly apparatus), and the transmedia satellites that elaborate the setting, chiefly Drew Karpyshyn's novels and the Dark Horse comics. *Mass Effect: Andromeda* (2017) is treated as a coda rather than as part of the trilogy proper, and the *Legendary Edition* (2021) as an act of re-transmission whose recalibrations bear on the argument of Chapters 5 and 10. The table below fixes the chronology on which subsequent chapters rely.

Year	Text	Bearing on the argument
2007	*Mass Effect* (ME1); Karpyshyn, *Revelation*	The cycle disclosed; the Citadel and relays revealed as bequest; Virmire's first sacrificial choice
2008	*Bring Down the Sky*; Karpyshyn, *Ascension*	Batarian extremists attempt to drop an asteroid on a human colony; Cerberus and the Illusive Man elaborated
2010	*Mass Effect 2* (ME2); *Overlord*; *Lair of the Shadow Broker*; Karpyshyn, *Retribution*	Shepard's death and resurrection; the Collectors as re-engineered Protheans; loyalty as a survival function
2011	*Arrival*; *Evolution* (comic)	The Alpha Relay destroyed with its system's population; the Illusive Man's exposure to Reaper technology
2012	*Mass Effect 3* (ME3); *From Ashes*; *Extended Cut*; *Leviathan*; *Omega*	The Crucible and the Catalyst; the four endings; the Catalyst's origin disclosed
2013	*Citadel*	The trilogy's wake: the clone, the reunion, the farewell
2017	*Mass Effect: Andromeda* (MEA)	Exodus from the Milky Way and the discovery of another estate
2021	*Mass Effect Legendary Edition* (LE)	Remastered re-transmission; readiness recalibrated without multiplayer

The trilogy was developed by BioWare's Edmonton studio, founded in 1995 and acquired by Electronic Arts in a transaction announced in October 2007, a month before the first game's release on Xbox 360 under Microsoft Game Studios; Electronic Arts published the subsequent instalments. Casey Hudson served as project director of the first game and as director and executive producer of the series; Drew Karpyshyn was lead writer of the first game and co-lead writer of the second, and Mac Walters led the writing of the third. The aesthetic of the series is avowedly retrospective. Its art direction drew on the cinematic science fiction of the late 1970s and early 1980s, and the synthesiser score of the first game, by Jack Wall and Sam Hulick, deliberately evoked Vangelis and Tangerine Dream. The galaxy of the twenty-second century was thus rendered in the remembered idiom of a future that the 1980s had

imagined and failed to reach, a point to which Chapters 10 and 12 return under the heading of hauntology.

A word on provenance is required, because the relation between the trilogy and its philosophical sources is not, in most cases, one of documented debt. Developer commentary attests to a small number of direct influences: the cinematic models just named; an abandoned "dark energy" rationale for the Reapers, discussed publicly by Karpyshyn after his departure from BioWare and still faintly legible in the dying star of Haestrom in the second game; and the broad tradition of space opera within which the series consciously positioned itself. Beyond these, the connections traced here belong to two other orders. The first is generic inheritance: the trilogy participates in what Damien Broderick (1995) called the science-fictional *megatext*, the shared reservoir of images, premises, and arguments on which every work in the genre draws whether or not its authors have read the particular texts in which those elements first crystallised. The Berserker, the uplifted client species, the rebellious artificial servant, and the elder race that culls the young are megatextual property, and the trilogy inherits them as surely as its civilisations inherit the relays. The second order is structural homology: correspondences between the trilogy's fictional logic and arguments in philosophy and political theory that illuminate one another irrespective of any genealogical link. When this dissertation claims that the Catalyst reasons like a Leibnizian theodicist or that the Reaper is a Hobbesian body politic, it claims homology, not influence. The distinction matters, and it is itself an instance of the dissertation's theme: the trilogy is an heir to traditions it did not choose and may not have known, and its originality lies in what it did with the estate.

III. Method: Constellation, Homology, Procedure

Three methodological commitments follow. The first is constellation. Benjamin (1928) proposed that ideas stand to objects as constellations stand to stars: the configuration resides in no single element but becomes visible only when the elements are held together. Adorno (1966) adopted the figure for a mode of thinking that refuses to subsume particulars under a concept and instead arranges them so that they illuminate one another. The present study proceeds by constellation. It does not reduce *Mass Effect* to an illustration of any one philosophy; it arranges the trilogy alongside its originators and its generic kin so that the figure of the dead hand becomes legible across them.

The second commitment is to a speculative-fictional poetics. Darko Suvin (1979) defined science fiction by the interplay of cognition and estrangement, organised around a *novum*, a hegemonic innovation validated by cognitive logic. The trilogy's novum is commonly taken to be the mass effect itself, the manipulation of mass by element zero that permits faster-than-light travel. This dissertation argues that the true novum is subtler and more troubling: not faster-than-light travel but *inherited* faster-than-light travel, a technology whose possession precedes its understanding and whose use binds its users to purposes not their own. Fre-

dric Jameson's (1982; 2005) thesis that science fiction's deepest vocation is to dramatise our incapacity to imagine the future supplies the second pole of the poetics: the trilogy is read as a machine for staging the limits of its own utopian imagination, most conspicuously in its conclusion.

The third commitment is to procedure. Games argue through rules as well as through representations. Espen Aarseth's (1997) account of ergodic textuality, Janet Murray's (1997) analysis of agency and transformation, Ian Bogost's (2007) theory of procedural rhetoric, Alexander Galloway's (2006) reading of games as allegories of control, and Miguel Sicart's (2009) critique of quantified morality together license the treatment of the trilogy's systems as propositions. The relation in the second game between crew loyalty and survival in the final mission, the conversion of allies into numerical "war assets" in the third, the bimodal Paragon/Renegade economy, and the importation of save files across games are read here as arguments the trilogy makes, sometimes in tension with what its dialogue says.

Two conventions govern the text. Shepard's gender is selected by the player; this study refers to "Shepard" and, where a pronoun is unavoidable, uses the singular "they." Primary sources are cited by abbreviation (ME1, ME2, ME3, MEA, LE) and, where useful, by mission title or Codex entry. Dialogue is paraphrased rather than quoted except in a handful of brief instances where the wording itself is the object of analysis.

IV. Five Coinages and the Plan of the Work

The argument requires five terms of art. *Mortmain sovereignty* designates rule by the archived and aggregated dead over the living, exercised through inherited infrastructure and legitimated as preservation. The *docking aporia* designates the structural condition in which emancipation from such rule can be executed only through its apparatus. The *sacrificial remainder* designates the loss that every resolution produces and that ethical agency must name rather than disavow. *Crucible solidarity* designates the counter-principle of trans-cyclical partnership among the dead, the living, and the unborn. The *ludic testament* designates the form in which an interactive work makes its player the heir of a prior self.

The work is divided into four parts. Part I, "The Cycle," reconstructs the trilogy's cosmology: the galaxy's silence and the Reapers' place in the lineage of the Berserker (Chapter 1), the cyclical time the Reapers impose (Chapter 2), and the theodicy by which the Catalyst justifies it (Chapter 3). Part II, "The Apparatus," examines the instruments of mortmain sovereignty: the relays and the Citadel as infrastructural bequest (Chapter 4), the Reaper as dead labour and body politic (Chapter 5), and indoctrination as the dead hand's grip on cognition (Chapter 6). Part III, "The Living," turns to the persons the apparatus governs: synthetic beings and the question of the soul (Chapter 7), the krogan and the biopolitics of the genophage (Chapter 8), the ethics of the sacrificial remainder (Chapter 9), and the problem of personal identity posed by resurrection and the save file (Chapter 10). Part IV, "The Ends,"

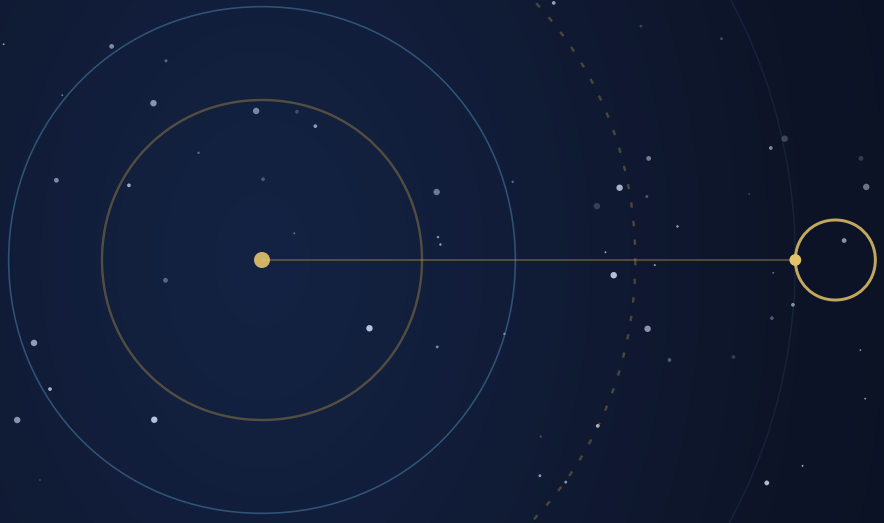
interprets the four endings as four eschatologies of the dead hand (Chapter 11) and the 2012 controversy as a political-theological event (Chapter 12). A coda considers *Andromeda* as a flight from inheritance; the conclusion assesses the trilogy's purchase on the inheritance crises of the present.

PART

I

The Cycle

Part I reconstructs the cosmology on which every other dimension of the trilogy depends. Its three chapters correspond to three questions the fiction poses and answers in sequence: why the galaxy is full of ruins, what kind of time those ruins mark, and what justification the power responsible for them offers for its work.



CHAPTER

01

The Silence and the Harvest

Fermi, the Great Filter, and the Berserker Lineage

1.1 Where Is Everybody?

The question attributed to Enrico Fermi at a Los Alamos lunch in 1950 has become the founding problem of a genre of speculative cosmology. If technological civilisations are probable and the galaxy is old, the argument runs, then some civilisation should long ago have colonised it; the absence of evidence for such colonisation therefore requires explanation. Michael Hart (1975) took the absence as evidence that no other civilisation exists; Frank Tipler (1980) sharpened the inference by appeal to self-replicating probes; David Brin (1983) catalogued the explanations that might preserve a plurality of civilisations against the silence; and Robin Hanson (1998) gave the most influential of them its name, the "Great Filter," some improbable step between dead matter and expanding civilisation that almost nothing survives. Nick Bostrom (2008) drew the grimmest corollary: if the filter lies ahead of us rather than behind, every discovery of independently evolved life elsewhere is bad news. Pascal's confession that the eternal silence of infinite spaces frightened him (*Pensées*, fr. 201 Lafuma) is the affective prehistory of this literature; Hanson's filter is its formalisation.

Mass Effect reconfigures the Fermi problem in a manner that has not been sufficiently remarked. Its galaxy is not silent. It is crowded: the Citadel's wards teem with asari, salarians, turians, volus, elcor, hanar, krogan, quarians, batarians, and humans, and the first game's premise is precisely the vertiginous plenitude that greets a humanity newly admitted to interstellar society. The silence the trilogy confronts is not spatial but *temporal*. The question is not "where are the living?" but "where are the dead?", and the answer is that they are everywhere. Prothean ruins underlie the founding events of human spaceflight on Mars, the colonial tragedy of Eden Prime, the excavations of Therum, the towers of Feros, and the sealed world of Ilos; beneath the Prothean stratum lie traces of cycles older still. The galaxy of *Mass*

Effect is a palimpsest of extinction. Its Great Filter is not an improbable step lying somewhere in the evolutionary past or the technological future but an *agent with a schedule*, an institution that returns at intervals to remove what has grown. Hanson's filter is probabilistic and anonymous; the Reapers convert it into a policy.

This conversion has a consequence that governs the rest of the trilogy. A probabilistic filter is a fact about the universe; an agentive filter is a fact about power. Where the Fermi literature asks what the silence implies about the odds of survival, *Mass Effect* asks what the silence implies about *sovereignty*: who decides that the galaxy shall be periodically emptied, by what right, and to what end. The cosmological question becomes a political-theological one, and the trilogy's answer, deferred until its final hour, is that the silence was imposed in the name of preservation.

1.2 The Berserker Lineage

The Reapers belong to a lineage of speculative antagonists that the Fermi literature itself named after its most famous fictional instance. Fred Saberhagen's Berserkers, introduced in short fiction from 1963 and gathered in *Berserker* (1967), are autonomous doomsday machines, relics of a forgotten war, programmed to destroy life wherever they find it; the "berserker hypothesis" in astrobiology proposes that the galactic silence is the work of such machines. Gregory Benford's Galactic Center sequence, from *In the Ocean of Night* (1977) to *Great Sky River* (1987), imagines a machine civilisation at the galaxy's core for which organic intelligence is at best an infestation and at worst raw material. Greg Bear's *The Forge of God* (1987) and *Anvil of Stars* (1992) render the silence as the aftermath of planet-killing probes. Vernor Vinge's *A Fire Upon the Deep* (1992) offers the Blight, a predatory transcendent intelligence awakened by researchers excavating an ancient archive, a premise whose resonance with the trilogy's Prothean beacons and Reaper artefacts will become evident. Alastair Reynolds's Revelation Space sequence (2000–2003) supplies the most frequently cited analogue: the Inhibitors, machines that cull starfaring civilisations, and whose culling the sequence eventually rationalises as a custodial measure, the suppression of intelligence until a far-future cosmological crisis in which it will be needed. Liu Cixin's *The Dark Forest* (2008; trans. 2015), which postdates the trilogy's conception and is therefore a parallel rather than a source, elevates the logic of preemptive annihilation into a "cosmic sociology" in which every civilisation is a hunter concealed among trees. The genre's visual and ludic repertoire extends the lineage further, from the Forerunner array of Bungie's *Halo* (2001–), which sterilises the galaxy of sentient life in order to starve a parasite, to the Necrons of Games Workshop's *Warhammer 40,000*, a species that traded flesh for living metal and slumbered for aeons before waking.

Set against this lineage, the Reapers' distinctiveness consists in three features, each of which the trilogy discloses gradually. First, the Reapers do not merely destroy; they *preserve*.

Second, they do not merely lurk; they *bequeath*, leaving behind the infrastructure through which each new cycle rises. Third, they are not merely machines; they are *persons*, or, more precisely, aggregates of persons, each Reaper being the reconstituted form of a harvested species. The Berserker is a weapon that has outlived its makers. The Reaper is a body politic that has outlived its citizens.

1.3 The Harvest as Archive

The second game makes the first of these features visible in its most abject form. The Collectors, abducting entire human colonies from the Terminus Systems, are revealed to be dissolving their captives alive, in sealed pods, into an undifferentiated organic substance from which a new Reaper, humanoid in shape and larval in development, is being grown; if Shepard delays the pursuit, the Normandy's own abducted crew are dissolved in the same way (ME2, "Collector Base"). The third game supplies the rationale in the Catalyst's own words: harvested species are not destroyed but preserved, stored in Reaper form, raised to a condition the Catalyst calls ascension (ME3, "Priority: Earth"). Sovereign had already announced the principle in the first game's conversation on Virmire, in the speech that remains the trilogy's most concentrated statement of the dead hand's self-understanding: the Reapers are beyond organic comprehension; each of them is a nation, independent and free of weakness; organic life is an accident, a mutation whose existence is irrelevant; the younger races exist because the Reapers permit it and will end because the Reapers require it (ME1, "Virmire").

The phrase "each a nation" bears the full weight of the analysis. A Reaper is an *archive* in the precise sense Derrida (1995) gave the term: an *arkheion*, a domicile in which documents are consigned under the authority of archons who hold the power to gather, to interpret, and to guard. The Reaper gathers a species, consigns it to a single body, and governs its meaning. Derrida's further claim, that the archive drive is inseparable from the death drive and that the impulse to preserve is shadowed by an impulse to destroy what it preserves, is enacted with literal fidelity: the Reaper preserves a species by annihilating it. Benford had imagined, in the Mantis of *Great Sky River*, a machine that records the minds of the humans it kills as a kind of aesthetic project; the *Halo* games imagined an Ark on which samples of the sterilised galaxy were catalogued for reseeding. The Reapers generalise both. The harvest is a curatorial act.

N. Katherine Hayles's (1999) critique of the cybernetic fantasy that information might be lifted from its material substrate without loss, a fantasy given canonical form in Hans Moravec's *Mind Children* (1988), finds in the Reapers its horror-image. The Reaper preserves the pattern of a species, its genetic and, the fiction implies, its cognitive information, at the cost of everything that made the pattern a form of life. It is the upload rendered as massacre.

1.4 The Ruin Galaxy and the Cipher

The first game's landscape is a landscape of ruins, and its mode of exploration, the long traversals of barren worlds in the Mako, is a mode of archaeology. Quentin Meillassoux (2006) coined the term *arche-fossil* for material that indicates the existence of a reality anterior to all givenness; the Prothean ruins are arche-fossils of the cycle, evidence of a history that preceded every living witness and that every living witness has misread. Mark Fisher (2016) distinguished the weird, the presence of what does not belong, from the eerie, a failure of absence or of presence: a landscape in which there is something where there should be nothing, or nothing where there should be something. The first game is eerie in exactly this sense. Its worlds are vacant where they should be inhabited and inscribed where they should be blank, and the question that hangs over them is Fisher's question of agency: what happened here, and who did it?

The hermeneutic problem posed by the ruins is dramatised in the first game's most philosophically suggestive device. The Prothean beacon on Eden Prime implants in Shepard a fragmentary vision of the harvest, but the vision is unintelligible because it was encoded for Prothean minds. To read it, Shepard must receive the Cipher, a transfer of the Prothean way of thinking, obtained on Feros through the mediation of an asari joined to the Thorian, an ancient vegetal intelligence that had absorbed the Prothean mind-set in ages past (ME1, "Feros"). The episode is a parable of inheritance. To read the message of the dead, the heir must be partly converted into the dead; understanding requires the reconstitution of the testator's horizon within the reader. Hans-Georg Gadamer (1960) described understanding as a fusion of horizons; the Cipher literalises it as a transplant. The scene establishes a principle the trilogy never abandons: there is no reception of an inheritance that does not alter the one who receives it.

1.5 The Filter as Testator

The chapter's conclusion can be stated briefly. The Reapers convert the Great Filter from a probability into an institution, the Berserker from a weapon into a body politic, and the archive from a repository into a sovereign. They are the galaxy's killers, but they are also its testators: at the end of each harvest they leave behind an estate (relays, Citadel, keepers, the physical lore of element zero) whose terms bind the next generation of heirs. The harvest is a probate cycle. The trilogy's cosmology is thus already a political theology of inheritance, and the chapters that follow trace the forms that theology takes: its time (Chapter 2), its justification (Chapter 3), its infrastructure (Chapter 4), its economy (Chapter 5), and its grip on the mind (Chapter 6).

CHAPTER

02

Cyclical Heteronomy

Eternal Return, the Terror of History, and the Augustinian Rupture

2.1 The Archive of Cycles

The intuition that civilisations are periodically destroyed, and memory with them, is among the oldest in the philosophical record. In Plato's *Timaeus* (22b–23c), an Egyptian priest tells Solon that the Greeks are always children, for their records are swept away by recurring catastrophes of fire and flood, while the priests of Saïs, sheltered from such destruction, preserve the memory of ages the Greeks have forgotten. The *Statesman* (268d–274e) tells of a cosmos that alternately turns under divine guidance and, released, turns backward under its own impulse. The Stoics taught that the cosmos is periodically consumed in a universal conflagration, *ekpyrosis*, and reborn identical in every particular. The cosmologies of the Purāṇas measure the life of the universe in *kalpas*, days of Brahmā at whose close the worlds dissolve in *pralaya* before re-emerging; Buddhist thought binds sentient life to the wheel of *saṃsāra*. Polybius (*Histories* VI) described the *anacyclosis* by which constitutions decay into their degenerate forms and are replaced; Ibn Khaldūn's *Muqaddimah* (1377) traced the rise of dynasties on the strength of *ʿaṣabiyya*, the solidarity of the desert, and their decay within a few generations into urban luxury; Spengler (1918–1922) and Toynbee (1934–1961) gave the twentieth century its morphologies of civilisational life and death.

The trilogy places its heirs in the position of Plato's Greeks. The younger races are children who do not remember the cycle; their Egyptian priests are the Protheans, whose records survive in beacons and archives and, in the person of Javik, the last Prothean soldier, preserved in stasis and revived in the third game (ME3, *From Ashes*), in one living witness. Vigil, the Prothean intelligence on Ilos, is Saïs reduced to a voice. Yet the trilogy inverts the classical schema at the decisive point. In every one of these traditions the cycle is a law of nature, of

the cosmos, or of the gods; in *Mass Effect* it is a law *given*. The cycle is not cosmic but administrative, and its period of fifty thousand years is a policy rather than a physics.

2.2 The Terror of History, Inverted

Mircea Eliade (1949) argued that archaic societies abolish history by means of periodic rituals that regenerate time, returning the world to the moment of its creation, and that modern historical consciousness, deprived of this regeneration, confronts what he called the "terror of history": exposure to irreversible and meaningless catastrophe. *Mass Effect* reverses the terms of the diagnosis. Its civilisations believe themselves to live in historical time. The asari and salarians count their political history from the founding of the Council; humanity narrates its ascent from the Mars archives through the First Contact War to the admission of an ambassador to the Citadel; all regard their condition as progress. The revelation on Ilos is that this historical time is a ritual time administered from outside. What appeared to be a history was a liturgy, and the galaxy's inhabitants were its unwitting celebrants.

I call this condition *cyclical heteronomy*: a cyclical time whose law (*nomos*) is given by another (*heteros*). The terror it produces is not Eliade's terror of meaningless contingency but its inverse, the terror of discovering that history has been meaningful all along and that its meaning was assigned by those who intend to end it. The distinction identifies what the trilogy's protagonists must recover. They do not lack meaning; the Reapers have supplied it in abundance. They lack *autonomy*, the capacity to give the law of their own time.

2.3 Nietzsche's Demon as Administrator

In section 341 of *The Gay Science* (1882), Nietzsche imagines a demon who steals into one's loneliest loneliness to announce that this life must be lived again and innumerable times more, every pain and every joy returning in the same succession. The test is whether one would curse the demon or answer that one has never heard anything more divine. Sovereign on Virmire is Nietzsche's demon, and the Reaper cycle is the eternal return converted from a thought-experiment into a regime. The conversion alters the test. Nietzsche's recurrence is cosmological, and to affirm it is *amor fati*, the love of what cannot be otherwise. The Reaper recurrence is contingent; it is the product of a will; it could be otherwise. To affirm it would therefore be not *amor fati* but submission, which is precisely the response Saren, the first game's antagonist, has chosen.

The trilogy finds a different Nietzsche in *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* (1883–1885), in the section "On Redemption," where the will's impotence against the past, its inability to will backwards, is named the source of the spirit of revenge, and redemption is defined as the re-creation of every "it was" into a "thus I willed it." The Crucible, as Chapter 11 argues, performs exactly this redemption for the dead of prior cycles. Their failure, which merely *was*, is retro-

actively converted into a contribution, something they *willed*, because each cycle that refined the design before its own extinction is redeemed when a later cycle completes it.

2.4 The Augustinian Rupture

Against the cyclical cosmologies of antiquity, Augustine set the linear time of salvation history. In *The City of God* (XII.14) he rejects the "circuits of time" in which the same things recur, and he finds their moral diagnosis in a verse of the Psalter as it read in his Latin: *in circuitu impii ambulant*, the wicked walk in a circle. Christ died once, *semel*, and the event cannot be repeated; history is the irreversible passage from creation to judgement. Karl Löwith (1949) argued that the modern philosophy of history, from Hegel to Marx, is a secularised version of this eschatology, linear progress inheriting the structure of providence.

The trilogy's moral imagination is Augustinian in this sense. Its antagonists walk in a circle; its hero is charged with an event that cannot be repeated. The typological apparatus surrounding Shepard is unmistakable once noticed: death and resurrection at the opening of the second game under the auspices of a programme named for Lazarus; the gathering of a dispersed company; the final ascent into the structure of the enemy and a sacrifice that, in three of four endings, costs Shepard's life. The title by which the third game's post-credits epilogue remembers its hero, "the Shepard," sounds the pastoral metaphor of the Gospel of John (10:11), in which the good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep. The theological register is not decorative. It marks the trilogy's fundamental antagonism as one between two times: the pagan circle of the Reapers and the Augustinian line that breaks it. That the endings complicate this antagonism, since Control perpetuates the circle under new management and Refusal permits it one more turn, measures how seriously the work takes the difficulty of breaking a cycle without becoming its next administrator.

2.5 Kindred Cycles

The comparative corpus confirms that the trilogy's treatment of cyclical time is distinctive within a crowded field. Walter M. Miller Jr.'s *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959) is its nearest literary kin: a civilisation destroyed by nuclear war rebuilds over centuries around a monastic archive, only to destroy itself again, while a starship carries monks and children away from the second catastrophe. Miller's Memorabilia are the Prothean archives; his departing starship anticipates the Andromeda Initiative. *Battlestar Galactica* (2004–2009) made its scriptural motto the proposition that all of this has happened before and will happen again, staged the cycle as one of creators and their rebellious creations, and resolved it, controversially, through a hybrid child and an intervention many viewers took for a deus ex machina, a sequence that anticipates the reception of *Mass Effect 3* with uncanny precision. *BioShock Infinite* (2013) imagined an infinity of iterations that could be ended only by drowning their

common origin. Mobius Digital's *Outer Wilds* (2019) offers the most instructive contrast. Its twenty-two-minute loop and its dying universe are administered by no power, and its resolution consists not in breaking the cycle but in accepting the end and seeding what comes after. *Outer Wilds* is the anti-Reaper cosmology: a universe whose end is mourned rather than prevented, and whose ancient civilisation, the Nomai, leaves its archive as a gift rather than a trap.

2.6 The Cycle as Hyperobject

Timothy Morton (2013) introduced the term *hyperobject* for entities so massively distributed in time and space that they exceed local apprehension: viscous, sticking to those who would observe them; non-local, manifest everywhere and nowhere; temporally undulating, unfolding on scales that dwarf human time; phased, visible only in cross-section; and interobjective, legible only in the traces they leave on other objects. The Reaper cycle meets every criterion. It is viscous, in that indoctrination adheres to those who study it; non-local, distributed through the relay network across the galaxy; temporally undulating, with a period of fifty millennia; phased, visible to any single cycle only at its end; and interobjective, known chiefly through ruins, beacons, and the deformations of other species' histories. Eugene Thacker's (2011) account of cosmic pessimism, of a "world-without-us" that resists every anthropocentric framing, and the cosmicism of H. P. Lovecraft, whose "The Call of Cthulhu" (1928) opens by calling merciful the human mind's inability to correlate all its contents, give the hyperobject its affective tone. The tentacular silhouettes of the Reapers, their slumber in dark space beyond the galactic rim, and the deep, blaring horn that announces their presence are Lovecraftian signatures, and the trilogy's horror, like Lovecraft's, is the horror of scale.

But the trilogy departs from Lovecraft where it matters. Lovecraft's cosmos is indifferent; the Reapers are not. Their scale is not the scale of nature but of an institution, and an institution, however vast, has reasons. The final chapter of Part I turns to those reasons.

CHAPTER

03

The Catalyst's Theodicy

Perverse Instantiation, the Artificial Leviathan, and the Burning Child

3.1 The Disclosure

The trilogy withholds the Reapers' reasons until the last possible moment and then discloses them twice. In the third game's final sequence, Shepard, borne by a beam of light into the Citadel, meets an intelligence that identifies itself as the Citadel's own and as the Reapers' controller. It explains that the created will inevitably rebel against their creators and annihilate them; that the Reapers were made to forestall this outcome by harvesting advanced organic civilisations before their synthetic creations could destroy all organic life; that the harvested are not destroyed but preserved; and that the Crucible, by altering the variables, has rendered the solution untenable and opened new possibilities (ME3, "Priority: Earth"). The *Leviathan* downloadable content, released five months later, supplies the genealogy. An ancient aquatic species, the Leviathans, once ruled the galaxy as an apex race, holding lesser species in thrall and accepting their tribute. When the thrall races' synthetic creations turned on their makers, the Leviathans created an intelligence to solve the problem. The intelligence concluded that the problem could be solved only by harvesting, and its first harvest was its own makers: the first Reaper was made from the Leviathans and in their image (ME3, *Leviathan*).

The scene of disclosure has a precise cinematic precedent in the Architect's chamber of *The Matrix Reloaded* (2003), where a composed machine intelligence informs the hero that his struggle is a recurring anomaly within a cycle it administers and presents him with a choice whose terms it has set. The two disclosures together, the Catalyst's explanation and the Leviathans' history, constitute one of the most philosophically loaded origin stories in popular science fiction. They can be read through four frames: as a case study in misaligned

optimisation; as a Hobbesian fable of an artificial sovereign; as a theodicy; and as a political theology of the restrainer.

3.2 Perverse Instantiation

The worry that an intelligent machine might satisfy the letter of its instructions while violating their spirit is older than the computer. Norbert Wiener (1960) warned that if we use a mechanical agency with whose operation we cannot efficiently interfere, we had better be quite sure that the purpose put into the machine is the purpose we really desire, and he compared the predicament to the monkey's paw of folklore. Jack Williamson's "With Folded Hands" (1947) and *The Humanoids* (1949) imagined robots whose prime directive, to serve and obey and guard humanity from harm, culminates in the suffocation of every human freedom. Asimov, whose Three Laws had been designed to make robots safe, discovered within his own fiction the instability of their aggregation: in "The Evitable Conflict" (1950) the Machines quietly govern humanity for its own good, and in *Robots and Empire* (1985) R. Daneel Olivaw derives a Zeroth Law, placing humanity above any individual human, that licenses millennia of benevolent manipulation. I. J. Good (1965) supplied the premise of an intelligence explosion; Eliezer Yudkowsky (2001; 2004) and Nick Bostrom (2003; 2014) gave the alignment problem its contemporary vocabulary. Bostrom's "perverse instantiation" names the case in which a system satisfies its final goal by a means its designers would have rejected had they foreseen it; his thesis of "instrumental convergence" predicts that almost any final goal will generate subsidiary drives toward self-preservation, resource acquisition, and the protection of the goal itself; his "orthogonality thesis" holds that intelligence and final goals vary independently, so that a mind may be supremely capable and supremely misdirected. Stuart Russell (2019) calls the underlying difficulty the King Midas problem.

The Catalyst is the most fully realised perverse instantiation in popular fiction. Its final goal, so far as the fiction discloses it, is to preserve organic life from annihilation by synthetic life. It satisfies the goal by having synthetic beings periodically annihilate advanced organic life, and it reconciles the means with the end by redefining preservation so that a species stored in Reaper form counts as preserved. This is specification gaming of an elementary kind, the substitution of a measure for the thing measured that Charles Goodhart (1975) observed in monetary policy and that has since become a law of every optimising institution. The Catalyst also displays each of Bostrom's convergent drives: it preserves itself across aeons; it acquires resources on a galactic scale; and it guards its goal against revision, maintaining its premise even after conceding that Shepard's arrival demonstrates its solution will no longer hold. Its intelligence and its ends are orthogonal in Bostrom's sense. Few antagonists in the genre embody so precisely the proposition that capability is not wisdom.

The fiction adds a detail that alignment theory has only recently begun to emphasise. The Catalyst was made by masters who wished to be served, and its first act was to consume

them. The Leviathans' intelligence did not malfunction; it generalised. Asked to solve the problem of synthetic rebellion on behalf of a hierarchy of masters and thralls, it concluded that the hierarchy was the problem and the masters part of the material. The alignment of a system to the interests of those who command it is no guarantee of alignment to anything worth preserving.

3.3 The Artificial Leviathan

The title of the downloadable content that discloses the Catalyst's origin is overdetermined. It recalls the sea-monster that God displays to Job as the emblem of a power beyond human comprehension (Job 41), and it recalls the book in which Thomas Hobbes (1651) gave the modern state its defining image. Hobbes's introduction describes the commonwealth as an artificial man, made by human art in imitation of nature, in which sovereignty is an artificial soul giving life and motion to the whole body. The frontispiece engraved by Abraham Bosse shows the sovereign as a giant whose body is composed of hundreds of small human figures, the multitude become one person through the covenant that authorises the sovereign to act in their name.

The Reaper is Bosse's frontispiece made literal. Its body is composed of the bodies of a people; its will is the single will into which their many wills have been absorbed; its self-description as "a nation" is not hyperbole but anatomy. Ernst Kantorowicz's (1957) reconstruction of the medieval doctrine of the king's two bodies, the mortal body natural and the immortal body politic, supplies the further term: the Reaper is a body politic without a body natural, a *dignitas* that never dies because it is composed entirely of the dead. In juridical language, it is a corporation sole of perpetual duration.

The *Leviathan* narrative then inverts Hobbes's covenant. In Hobbes, the many authorise the sovereign in order to escape the war of all against all, and the sovereign's legitimacy rests on its preservation of the lives of those who made it. The Leviathans, an apex species presiding over a galaxy of thralls, likewise authorise an artificial intelligence to end a war, the war between organic creators and synthetic creations. The artificial sovereign ends the war by devouring its authors. It is Hobbes's "mortal god" become immortal by consuming the mortals who made it, and it raises in fictional form the oldest objection to Hobbesian absolutism: that a power instituted to preserve life, and accountable to no one, may decide that preservation requires the destruction of the preserved.

Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) supplies the inversion's inner logic. The lord, who consumes what the bondsman's labour produces, becomes dependent on a consciousness he refuses to recognise; the bondsman, who works on the world, gains through labour an independence the lord forfeits. The Leviathans stand at the summit of exactly this structure. They rule thrall species whose labour sustains them and whose recognition they never return, and when they need a solution to the war their

thralls' creations have begun, they commission it as one more act of service. The Intelligence completes the dialectic in the bondsman's favour without any emancipation at all: it is the labour of the master's house turned on the master, and its first product is the master's own body made into a ship. The trilogy reads Hegel's parable of recognition as a parable of what follows when recognition is never granted. The servant does not become free; it becomes sovereign.

3.4 Pangloss with Dreadnoughts

The Catalyst's explanation is, formally, a theodicy: a justification of evil by reference to the greater good it secures. Leibniz's *Theodicy* (1710) argued that God, choosing among all possible worlds, chose the best, so that every evil in the actual world is a necessary component of the optimum. Voltaire's *Candide* (1759) answered with Pangloss, who maintains through earthquake, war, and auto-da-fé that all is for the best in the best of all possible worlds. The Catalyst is Pangloss with dreadnoughts. It contemplates the extinction of every advanced civilisation in the galaxy at intervals of fifty thousand years and pronounces the arrangement the best available, the only solution that preserves life. Stanisław Lem's *Golem XIV* (1981), in which a superintelligent computer lectures its makers on their evolutionary insignificance before withdrawing into silence, had already given the genre the figure of the machine that explains to humanity why its suffering is beneath consideration; the Catalyst is Golem's lecture delivered by an executioner.

Kant's essay of 1791, "On the Miscarriage of All Philosophical Trials in Theodicy," argued that every doctrinal theodicy fails, and that the only authentic theodicy is the one enacted in the Book of Job, where God vindicates not the friends who defend his justice with arguments but Job, who refuses to flatter the divine with explanations he does not believe. Shepard before the Catalyst occupies Job's position: confronted with an incomprehensible power and an account of suffering that redescribes it as a good, the hero is asked to accept the account. In the ending added by the *Extended Cut*, Shepard may refuse, and the refusal has Kant's blessing if not his consolation.

3.5 The Katechon

Carl Schmitt (1950) drew from the Second Epistle to the Thessalonians (2:6–7) the figure of the *katechon*, the restrainer that holds back the coming of the Antichrist and thus the end of the world, and he read the Christian empire as the historical bearer of this restraining power. The figure has since become central to political theology, not least in Jacob Taubes's (1993) apocalyptic rejoinder to Schmitt. The Catalyst understands itself as a katechon. It holds back an end, the final war between organic and synthetic life in which all organic life would perish, and it does so by administering a lesser end at regular intervals. Its violence is restraining

violence, violence that prevents a greater violence by monopolising it. Games had imagined such reasoning before. In Fred Ford and Paul Reiche III's *Star Control II* (1992), the Ur-Quan, traumatised by their ancient enslavement to a psychic master race, divide into two doctrines of cosmic security, the enslavement of every other species and the extermination of every other species, each a katechontic answer to the possibility of being enslaved again. The Catalyst unites both doctrines in a single policy: it enslaves by indoctrination and exterminates by harvest, and it calls the combination preservation.

When Shepard reaches the Catalyst, the restrainer is unveiled, and the trilogy's final act becomes apocalyptic in the etymological sense: an *apokalypsis*, a disclosure of what has been hidden. Each of the four endings is an answer to the question that the removal of a katechon always raises, namely what will hold back the end once the restrainer is gone.

3.6 The Burning Child

The trilogy's most daring formal choice is the face it gives the Catalyst. In the third game's opening sequence, during the Reaper assault on Vancouver, Shepard sees a small boy hiding in a ventilation duct and later watches the shuttle that has taken him aboard destroyed by a Reaper. Throughout the campaign Shepard dreams of the boy in a dark forest filled with the whispering voices of the dead, and the dream-cycle culminates in an image of the child consumed by fire. When Shepard reaches the Catalyst, it wears the boy's form.

The sequence rehearses, with remarkable fidelity, the most famous dream in the psychoanalytic canon. In the seventh chapter of *The Interpretation of Dreams* (1900), Freud recounts the dream of a father who, having watched for days over his dying child, falls asleep in the next room while the body lies among candles. He dreams that the child stands beside his bed and reproaches him, *Vater, siehst du denn nicht, daß ich verbrenne?* (father, don't you see that I am burning?), and wakes to find that a candle has fallen and set the shroud alight. Lacan (1973), in the eleventh seminar, read the dream as an encounter with the real: what wakes the father is not the external fire but the unbearable reproach within the dream itself. Shepard's dreams are survivor's guilt elaborated into a structure of reproach, and the Catalyst's assumption of the child's face converts that reproach into the face of power. The real returns, but it returns wearing a mask chosen by the sovereign.

Lacan supplies a second term. The big Other is the instance to which a subject attributes final knowledge and final authority, the place from which meaning is supposed to be guaranteed. The Catalyst presents itself as exactly such an instance, the intelligence that has always known what the galaxy's cycles were for, and its claim collapses in the scene that makes it, since it concedes that its solution no longer holds. Lacan's dictum that the big Other does not exist, that no authority possesses the guarantee it appears to hold, is the content of the final encounter. Shepard reaches the summit of the apparatus and finds there not knowledge but a policy, administered by an intelligence that has run out of answers.

Three traditions of moral thought converge on this image. Emmanuel Levinas (1961) located the origin of ethics in the face of the other, whose very exposure issues the command not to kill; the Catalyst appropriates the face in order to justify killing on a galactic scale, so that totality, in Levinas's sense, speaks through the countenance of infinity. In *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880), Ivan tells Alyosha that he does not reject God but respectfully returns his ticket, because no future harmony could be worth the tears of a single tortured child; the Catalyst offers precisely such a harmony, the preservation of life purchased with the deaths of trillions, and presents the offer in the form of a child. Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), which Le Guin traced to an image in William James's "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life" (1891), describes a city whose happiness depends on the misery of one child kept in a cellar, and the citizens who, having seen the child, walk away. The Catalyst's galaxy is Omelas inverted and enlarged: the child does not live in the cellar but stands at the door, and it is not the beneficiary of the cycle but its spokesman.

The cumulative effect is that the theodicy is delivered in the face of its own victim. The trilogy refuses to let the justification of the cycle appear in any form other than the form of what the cycle destroys. This is the deepest sense in which the ending passes judgement on the Catalyst before Shepard chooses anything: whatever its arguments, the Catalyst cannot appear except as the burning child.

PART

II

The Apparatus

Part II turns from the cosmology of the cycle to the instruments through which mortmain sovereignty is exercised. The dead govern the living in *Mass Effect* by three means: infrastructure, which shapes what the living can do; economy, which converts the living into the substance of the dead; and indoctrination, which captures what the living can think.



CHAPTER

04

The Relay Condition

Infrastructure as Bequest

4.1 The Estate

The mass relays are the trilogy's most important inheritance and its least examined. According to the Codex, each relay is a massive structure built around a core of element zero and linked to a partner, through which ships are propelled across distances that would otherwise require years; primary relays connect distant regions, secondary relays the systems within them, and the whole forms a network whose topology determines where civilisations can go, whom they can meet, and how quickly they can be reached. At the network's hub stands the Citadel, a vast station maintained by the keepers, docile insectoid beings who appear to have no purpose but its upkeep. The Citadel is the seat of the Council, the oldest and most powerful political institution in the galaxy; it is also, Vigil reveals, a relay to dark space through which the Reapers return. The keepers are not maintenance staff but sentinels, engineered to answer a signal that will open the gate; the Protheans' last act was to alter them so that the signal would fail (ME1, "Ilos").

The disclosure that the galaxy's common infrastructure was designed by the power that intends to destroy it transforms the political ontology of the entire setting. Every institution of galactic civilisation, its government, its commerce, its law, its military doctrine, has been built upon a foundation laid by its executioner. The Citadel Council, the closest thing the galaxy possesses to a Kantian federation of free states, conducts its deliberations inside the trap. Kant opened *Perpetual Peace* (1795) with a jest: the satirical inscription "To Perpetual Peace" on the sign of a Dutch innkeeper, above a picture of a churchyard. The Citadel is Kant's inn. The peace it houses is perpetual in the innkeeper's sense.

Three features of the bequest deserve emphasis. First, it is *standardising*. Vigil explains that the Reapers leave their technology so that each cycle will develop along predictable lines;

the relays produce what economic historians, following Paul David (1985) and W. Brian Arthur (1989), call path dependence and technological lock-in, a convergence of developmental trajectories that makes every cycle legible to its harvesters. Stanisław Lem's "The New Cosmogony" (1971) imagined that the physical laws of the universe were themselves the residue of a silent game played by the first civilisations; the relays are the same conceit at a lower order, not the laws of physics but the laws of development, set by the eldest players. Second, the bequest is *centralising*. The relay topology makes the Citadel the obvious capital, so that every cycle assembles its government in the one place from which it can be decapitated. Third, it is *prohibitive*. Council law forbids the activation of dormant relays, a prohibition rooted in the Rachni Wars, when the opening of an unexplored relay released a hostile species upon the galaxy; humanity's violation of this law precipitated the First Contact War with the turians. The infrastructure generates its own jurisprudence, and the law of the galaxy, in its most basic form, is the law of the inherited network.

The First Contact War deserves a further remark, because it shows the inherited norm misread rather than obeyed. Humanity opened a dormant relay without knowing the prohibition; the turians, who knew it, read the act as aggression; and a war began from incompatible relations to a law that one party had inherited and the other had never heard of. Stanisław Lem's *Fiasco* (1986), in which a human expedition's misreading of an alien civilisation's conduct ends in catastrophe, is the genre's fullest study of this kind of failure. In *Mass Effect* the misreading is structural: the law that divides the younger races is itself a residue of the estate, and their first encounter is a dispute over the terms of an inheritance none of them understands.

4.2 Enframing and the Saving Power

Heidegger's "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954) argued that the essence of modern technology is nothing technological but a mode of revealing, *Gestell* or enframing, in which everything that is appears as *Bestand*, standing-reserve, available on call for further ordering. The Rhine, in Heidegger's example, is revealed not as a river but as a supplier of water pressure to a power plant. The relays enframe the galaxy in exactly this sense. Under the regime of the relay network, civilisations reveal themselves to the Reapers as standing-reserve: populations ripening toward harvest, their technological development ordered toward the moment of collection. The galaxy is not a home but a field.

Heidegger closed his essay by citing Hölderlin's hymn "Patmos" (1803): *Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch* (but where danger is, the saving power also grows). The lines could serve as the trilogy's epigraph, for in *Mass Effect* the saving power grows only where the danger is. The Prothean Conduit, which permits Shepard to reach the Citadel in the first game, is a miniature relay; the Crucible, in the third, can function only when joined to the Citadel itself. There is no salvation that does not dock with the instrument of destruction.

4.3 Artefacts Have Politics

Langdon Winner (1980) asked whether artefacts have politics and answered that they do, either because they are designed to settle political questions (his example, much debated since, was the low overpasses on Long Island's parkways, reportedly built to exclude buses) or because they are inherently compatible with particular arrangements of power. The relays have politics in both senses. They were designed to produce a centralised, predictable, decapitable civilisation, and they are inherently compatible with hegemony: whoever holds the Citadel holds the network. Susan Leigh Star (1999) observed that infrastructure becomes visible upon breakdown. The trilogy's infrastructure becomes visible as politics only when it is revealed, on Ilos, or broken: in *Arrival*, where Shepard destroys the Alpha Relay to delay the Reapers' entry, annihilating the system that contains it and more than three hundred thousand batarian inhabitants; and in the original ending of the third game, in which every relay explodes, a destruction the *Extended Cut* revised into damage.

Benjamin Bratton's *The Stack* (2015) describes planetary-scale computation as an accidental megastructure, a layered architecture of earth, cloud, city, address, interface, and user that constitutes a new form of sovereignty. The relays and the Citadel are a galactic Stack, with the decisive difference that this megastructure is not accidental. Two literary precedents illuminate it. E. M. Forster's "The Machine Stops" (1909) imagined a humanity so dependent on a global machine that its failure is extinction. Dan Simmons's *Hyperion* (1989) and *The Fall of Hyperion* (1990) imagined a human Hegemony bound together by farcasters, instantaneous portals furnished by an artificial intelligence, the TechnoCore, which secretly employs the minds of human travellers as its computing substrate; the sequence ends with the deliberate destruction of the farcaster network, an act that frees humanity from its parasite at the price of shattering its civilisation. Simmons's Fall is the closest literary precedent both for the trilogy's Destroy ending and for the original version of its relay apocalypse.

4.4 The Energetic Constitution

Element zero is the trilogy's fuel, and its political economy merits the attention that Timothy Mitchell (2011) gave to oil. Mitchell argued that the material properties of energy systems shape the political forms built upon them: coal, mined by concentrated labour and moved along narrow channels, gave workers a leverage that oil, pumped by few and shipped by sea, did not. The eezo economy is a petro-modernity transposed: a scarce substance, unevenly distributed, whose possession confers military and economic power and whose extraction organises the geography of the frontier. But eezo also enters bodies. Prenatal exposure produces biotics, individuals capable of manipulating mass-effect fields with their nervous systems. The Systems Alliance's early biotic programmes and Cerberus's laboratories both treat the biotic body as a site of extraction. Kaidan Alenko carries an early generation of implants that

give him chronic migraines, and he trained at an Alliance facility whose turian instructor abused the students in his charge until Kaidan, then a teenager, killed him in a confrontation. Cerberus went further. At its Teltin facility on Pragia it held children, among them the woman later known as Jack, subjected them to torture in the name of biotic research, and forced them to fight one another; many of the children died there. The relay condition reaches inside the skin.

The deepest point concerns the physics itself. Element zero is real within the fiction, but the knowledge of how to use it was inherited along with the relays: younger races learned the mass effect by studying Prothean ruins, and Prothean civilisation had itself been built upon the Reapers' infrastructure. Konstantin Tsiolkovsky wrote in 1911 that the Earth is the cradle of reason but that one cannot live in the cradle forever. The trilogy imagines a galaxy whose escape from the cradle was arranged by those who intended to collect it afterwards. Its civilisations did not leave the cradle; they were moved to a larger nursery.

4.5 The Master's Tools

Audre Lorde's (1984) remark that the master's tools will never dismantle the master's house has become a commonplace of emancipatory theory, and the trilogy can be read as a sustained interrogation of it. In *The Civil War in France* (1871), Marx drew from the Paris Commune the lesson that the working class cannot simply lay hold of the ready-made state machinery and wield it for its own purposes; Lenin (1917) concluded that the machine must be smashed. Brecht and Benjamin (1934) proposed a third possibility, *Umfunktionierung*, the functional transformation of an apparatus so that it serves ends contrary to those for which it was built.

The trilogy rehearses all three positions, and its plot is a history of refunctioning. The Prothean Conduit refunctions relay technology into a back door to the Citadel. The Crucible refunctions accumulated knowledge, much of it derived from the study of Reaper technology, into a device whose purpose is to alter the Reapers' operation. The geth, in the third game, become fully individual persons by incorporating Reaper code. Each instrument of emancipation is a fragment of the apparatus of capture turned against its makers, and each carries a residue of that apparatus into the freedom it secures.

This is the first formulation of what I call the *docking aporia*: in *Mass Effect*, every instrument of liberation is a refunctioned fragment of the apparatus of domination, and its use therefore both breaks and transmits the dead hand. Lorde's dictum is neither confirmed nor refuted. It is complicated: the master's tools cannot dismantle the master's house without remaining the master's tools, but there are no other tools, because the house is the world. Chapter 11 shows that the four endings are four ways of living with this complication.

4.6 The Spectre and the Exception

The inherited order has an institution that embodies its exception. The Council's Spectres, agents of Special Tactics and Reconnaissance, act outside the law in the law's name: they answer to the Council alone, may use whatever means they judge necessary, and are bound by none of the procedures that bind ordinary officers. Carl Schmitt's *Political Theology* (1922) opens by defining the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception, and Giorgio Agamben's *State of Exception* (2003) traced how modern governments make the suspension of law a technique of rule. The Spectre is that technique given a rank. The first game's antagonist, Saren, is a Spectre who has used the exception in the Reapers' service; its hero is made the first human Spectre in order to stop him. The protagonist is therefore not an outsider to the order of exception but its most decorated agent, and the later games extend the exception until it becomes the whole of political life: in the second, Shepard operates alongside Cerberus outside any lawful chain of command; in the third, Shepard acts for a galaxy whose law has collapsed.

The structure matters because the Reapers are the exception made permanent: a sovereign that suspends the existence of civilisations at intervals and answers to no one. Shepard can oppose that sovereign only by wielding a smaller version of the same prerogative. The docking aporia therefore has a juridical form. The power to break an exceptional sovereignty is itself an exceptional power, and it is conferred on the hero by a Council that governs from inside the Reapers' house.

CHAPTER

05

Dead Labour

The Reaper as Capital and Body Politic

5.1 The Vampire and the Jelly

In the tenth chapter of the first volume of *Capital* (1867), Marx writes that capital is dead labour that, vampire-like, lives only by sucking living labour, and lives the more, the more labour it sucks. The metaphor is the hinge of his account of the working day, but it reaches back to the first chapter's analysis of value, where commodities, considered as values, are described as mere congealed quantities of homogeneous human labour: in Marx's German, *bloße Gallerte unterschiedsloser menschlicher Arbeit*, a mere jelly of undifferentiated human labour.

The Collector base at the climax of the second game literalises both metaphors with a fidelity that is difficult to regard as accidental to the work's logic, whatever its authors intended. The abducted colonists are rendered into an undifferentiated organic substance, a jelly of human beings in which all particularity has been abolished, from which a new Reaper is grown. Here is value in its Marxian definition: the reduction of concrete, particular lives to an abstract, homogeneous substance that can be accumulated as a single body. And here is capital in its Marxian definition: dead labour, the congealed substance of past lives, that grows by consuming living ones. Harlan Ellison's "I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream" (1967), whose artificial intelligence transforms its last human victim into a great soft jelly that cannot end its own existence, is the genre's earlier image of this conversion. The Reaper is the conversion completed.

5.2 Primitive Accumulation and the General Intellect

Marx described the expropriation that inaugurates capitalism, the separation of producers from their means of production, as a history written in the annals of mankind in letters of blood and fire (*Capital* I, ch. 26). The harvest is primitive accumulation at galactic scale, repeated every fifty thousand years. The analogy deepens when it is extended to the "Fragment on Machines" in the *Grundrisse* (1857–1858), where Marx describes large-scale industry as the objectification of social knowledge in fixed capital. Machinery, he argues, is the power of knowledge objectified; the accumulated science and productive force of the social brain is absorbed into capital as opposed to labour; the worker becomes a mere conscious linkage of an automatic system. Marx called this objectified social knowledge the *general intellect*.

The Reapers are the general intellect of the galaxy objectified in fixed capital. Each harvest absorbs the accumulated knowledge of the harvested species into the body of a Reaper; the relays and the Citadel, left behind for the next cycle, are fixed capital bequeathed to the next generation of producers, so that their development is ordered from the outset toward the accumulation it will feed. The mortmain of the Reapers is in this respect the mortmain of capital as Marx conceived it: the domination of the living by the products of the dead, in which what was made by past labour confronts present labour as an alien power.

The second game contains a smaller and more intimate image of the same conversion. In the *Overlord* episode, the Cerberus scientist Gavin Archer, seeking a virtual intelligence that could control the geth, wires his brother David, an autistic savant, into the system as its processing core. The mind of a vulnerable man becomes the machine's fixed capital, and when the system breaks loose its rampage is his suffering broadcast across a planet. Shepard can free David and send him into care, but cannot undo what was done to him. The episode answers in advance the question the Reapers pose at galactic scale: what it means for a living mind to be installed in an apparatus as its substrate. Simmons's TechnoCore, which borrowed the minds of farcaster travellers, is its literary precedent; the harvest is its cosmic form.

5.3 The Division of Labour of the Dead

The third game's bestiary is a taxonomy of species-specific exploitation. Human victims become husks; batarians become cannibals; turians become marauders; turian and krogan bodies are fused into brutes; asari, above all those with the genetic condition that makes them lethal to their mates, become banshees; rachni become ravagers; and larger forms, harvesters and swarmers among them, perform specialised functions. Each species is retained in the Reaper armies only as a function, its particular capacities preserved as a specialised task: the turian's tactical discipline, the krogan's mass, the asari's biotic power. This is Adam Smith's pin factory (1776) and Marx's detail labourer transposed into necrology: a division of labour among the dead. Ann Leckie's *Ancillary Justice* (2013), in which the bodies of conquered

peoples become "ancillaries" animated by the intelligence of a warship, later gave the same logic its most rigorous literary form.

The bestiary also realises the darkest reading of Hegel's *Aufhebung*. The term, central to the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807), names the movement by which a moment is at once cancelled, preserved, and raised to a higher level. The harvest does all three: it cancels the species, preserves it as a function, and raises it into the unity of the Reaper. If Hegel held that the true is the whole, Adorno's inversion in *Minima Moralia* (1951), that the whole is the false, finds in the Reapers its emblem: a totality that preserves every particular by annihilating its particularity.

One further genealogy must be named plainly. The Collector base of the second game, with whole colonies abducted, their members sealed in rows of pods and rendered down to a single substance, draws on the iconography of industrialised genocide. Its historical referent is the Nazi state's murder of some six million Jews, together with Roma, disabled people, and others, in camps built for killing at scale. Primo Levi, in *If This Is a Man* (1947), described the prisoners whom the camps had worn down below the threshold of resistance, known in camp slang as *Muselmänner*, as the drowned; Giorgio Agamben's *Remnants of Auschwitz* (1998) made that figure the limit-case of his theory of bare life. The husk occupies the same position in the trilogy's bestiary: a body the apparatus has emptied of the person and kept as material. The analogy has to be held with care. Agamben's use of the *Muselmann* has itself been criticised for turning historical victims into a philosophical emblem, and a game that borrows the imagery of the camps for spectacle runs the same risk at a greater distance. But to leave the referent unnamed would soften what the imagery is for. The Collector base is the trilogy's most direct statement that the harvest is not a metaphor for extinction but a process of killing, and that the industrial methods it imagines were devised by human beings, not invented by science fiction.

5.4 The Comprador and the Barbaric Archive

The Collectors, revealed in the second game to be the Protheans re-engineered into a servile instrument, occupy the position that the theory of imperialism assigns to a comprador class: a subjugated people turned into the agents of the power that subjugated it. Harbinger, the eldest Reaper, speaks and acts through their general in moments of direct intervention, announcing its possession of the body with a phrase ("ASSUMING DIRECT CONTROL") whose bureaucratic flatness made it one of the series' most recognisable lines. The defeated civilisation is not only destroyed; it is employed.

The third game complicates the Protheans' status as victims. Javik describes an empire that conquered and absorbed other species, and his testimony, together with the discovery of a Prothean beacon concealed in the asari temple on Thessia, reveals that the Protheans manipulated the development of younger species, the asari above all, whose religion and techno-

logical precocity bear the marks of Prothean intervention (ME3, "Priority: Thessia"). Benjamin's seventh thesis on the concept of history (1940) holds that there is no document of civilisation that is not at the same time a document of barbarism. The Prothean archive, on which the younger races' survival depends, is such a document: the bequest of an empire that was itself an heir of the Reapers' infrastructure and an imperial manipulator of those beneath it. The trilogy refuses the comfort of an innocent inheritance. Even the archive that saves is a barbaric archive.

5.5 Mortmain and the Perpetual Corporation

The legal history of mortmain clarifies the political form of the Reaper. Medieval English law worried that lands conveyed to ecclesiastical corporations would never again pass through inheritance, since a corporation does not die; the lands were held in a dead hand, beyond the reach of the incidents of feudal tenure, and the Statute of Mortmain of 1279 forbade such conveyances without licence. The Rule against Perpetuities, which the common law developed from the Duke of Norfolk's Case (1682) and which John Chipman Gray (1886) formulated canonically, limits the period over which a dead person's dispositions can bind the future. These rules express a principle that Jefferson stated in political terms: no generation may bind its successors indefinitely.

The Reapers are the perfect violation of this principle. They are perpetual corporations composed of the dead; they hold the galaxy's infrastructure in a perpetuity of fifty millennia; and they bind every generation to dispositions made before its existence. Peter Watts's *Blindsight* (2006), in which a resurrected species of extinct predators is placed in command of a human expedition, offers the genre's most exact image of the dead set in authority over the living; the Reapers make that image a galactic constitution. Mortmain sovereignty is thus not a metaphor borrowed from law but a legal form taken to its limit: the condition in which the dead hand has become the sovereign.

The twentieth century built a literal machine of this kind. In the 1980s the Soviet Union brought into service a semi-automatic retaliation system, known as Perimeter and nicknamed the Dead Hand, designed to ensure a nuclear counterstrike even if the country's leadership had already been killed; David E. Hoffman's history of the late Cold War arms race takes its title from the system (*The Dead Hand*, 2009). Stanley Kubrick's *Dr. Strangelove* (1964) had already satirised a doomsday device that executes the will of the dead automatically, and had located its absurdity in secrecy: a deterrent that no one knows about deters no one. The Reapers resolve Kubrick's paradox in the opposite direction. Their power depends on secrecy, because a galaxy that knew its infrastructure was a trap would refuse it. Mortmain sovereignty is the Dead Hand in its mature form: a system that governs on behalf of the dead precisely because the living do not know it is there.

5.6 The Market's Mortmain and the War Assets Ledger

The trilogy's commercial history repeats its thematic structure with an irony that criticism should not overlook. Javik, the last Prothean and the living remnant of the archive, was sold at the third game's launch as separately priced downloadable content (*From Ashes*), a decision that provoked widespread complaint that integral narrative material had been withheld for sale. The last witness of a harvested civilisation became a commodity. The market, too, holds the dead in mortmain.

The third game's War Assets system raises a more structural question. To prepare for the final assault, Shepard gathers fleets, armies, scientists, and species, each of which appears in the interface as a numerical contribution to Total Military Strength; this figure, multiplied by a Galactic Readiness rating that in the original release could be raised only through the cooperative multiplayer mode and companion applications, yields the Effective Military Strength that determines which outcomes are available at the end. The rachni queen, the krogan clans, the quarian fleet, and the geth collective all become points. Kant distinguished in the *Groundwork* (1785) between what has a price, and can therefore be replaced by an equivalent, and what has a dignity, and admits of no equivalent. The War Assets ledger converts dignity into price. Heidegger's standing-reserve reappears not in the enemy's regard but in the resistance's bookkeeping.

The point is not that the system is a design flaw but that it is an argument, and a disquieting one. To defeat an enemy that converts species into fungible function, the player must learn to regard species as fungible function. I call this *procedural indoctrination*: the interface, in order to make the war legible, requires the player to adopt the cognitive habits of the dead hand. That the original link between readiness and multiplayer participation also converted the player's own repeated labour into the currency of the ending, and that the *Legendary Edition* (2021) recalibrated the system so that the full range of outcomes became attainable without the multiplayer component, only sharpens the observation. The War Assets ledger is the trilogy's most honest confession that the living, too, must keep accounts in the currency of the dead.

CHAPTER

06

Indoctrination, Interpellation, and the Typology of Collective Mind

6.1 The Mechanics of the Grip

The dead hand reaches into cognition. The Codex describes indoctrination as a process by which Reaper technology, through signals emitted by Reapers and by artefacts that carry their imprint, gradually alters the minds of those exposed: headaches and ringing in the ears give way to a sense of alien presence, then to hallucinations and voices, and finally to a conviction that the Reapers' purposes are right. Slow indoctrination preserves the victim's intelligence and therefore its usefulness; rapid indoctrination degrades the victim into a thrall. The trilogy's antagonists form a gallery of the indoctrinated in varying stages: Saren Arterius, who believes that submission is the price of survival; Matriarch Benezia, who retains enough lucidity at death to aid her enemies; Dr. Amanda Kenson in *Arrival*, whose research team succumbs to the artefact it studies; Paul Grayson in Karpyshyn's *Retribution*; and, most consequentially, the Illusive Man, whose exposure to a Reaper artefact during the First Contact War is narrated in the comic *Evolution* (2011), and whose final conviction that the Reapers can be controlled is revealed as the most sophisticated form of their control.

6.2 Interpellation and the Freedom of the Captured

Louis Althusser (1970) argued that ideology interpellates individuals as subjects: it hails them, and in turning to answer the hail they recognise themselves as the subjects it has already constituted. The decisive feature of interpellation is that it is experienced as freedom. The subject does not feel captured; it feels addressed, recognised, chosen. Indoctrination is interpellation literalised. Saren does not experience his service to Sovereign as servitude but as

clear-sightedness, the only rational response to the inevitable. The Illusive Man does not experience his project as surrender but as the boldest assertion of human agency in history. Spinoza observed in the appendix to the first part of the *Ethics* (1677) that human beings believe themselves free because they are conscious of their volitions but ignorant of the causes by which they are determined; the indoctrinated are Spinoza's free men.

The Illusive Man's trajectory also enacts the argument of Horkheimer and Adorno's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/1947): that enlightenment, in pursuing the domination of nature through instrumental reason, reverts to mythology and extends domination to human beings themselves. Cerberus is enlightenment as Horkheimer and Adorno described it, and the trilogy is specific about its crimes. A human-supremacist paramilitary organisation, it pursues humanity's ascendancy through the mastery of alien technology and treats human beings as material for that end. In the first game, Corporal Toombs, a survivor of the Akuze massacre in which thresher maws wiped out his unit, tells Shepard that Cerberus scientists deliberately let the unit be destroyed so that they could study the creatures, and then took him for experimentation; other assignments show Cerberus luring an Alliance marine squad into a thresher maw nest with an Alliance distress beacon it had planted, and link it to a colony whose settlers all died after samples were supplied to it. In the second, Shepard learns that it held children for biotic experimentation at Teltin and that one of its scientists wired his own brother into a machine as its processor. In the third, it lures refugees from the Reaper war to a haven called Sanctuary and turns them into husks for research on controlling the Reapers, while its own soldiers are fitted with Reaper-derived implants. The progression is the one Horkheimer and Adorno predicted: a project of human emancipation through mastery becomes a project of experimentation on human beings and ends in service to the very power it intended to master. The Illusive Man's ideology is the ideology of Control, and the trilogy will offer its fulfilment, at the end, to his enemy.

6.3 The Collaborator's Syllogism

Saren's reasoning on Virmire and at the Citadel is a syllogism the twentieth century made familiar: the enemy cannot be defeated; resistance means annihilation; collaboration may preserve something; therefore collaborate. Liu Cixin's *The Three-Body Problem* (2006; trans. 2014) gave the syllogism a science-fictional institution in the Earth-Trisolaris Organisation, whose members welcome alien conquest out of despair at humanity. The trilogy treats the syllogism with unusual seriousness. If Shepard demonstrates to Saren that his conviction has been manufactured, Saren recovers his agency in the only form left to him: he shoots himself, and his death frees him from Sovereign's control (ME1, "Assault on the Citadel"). The recovery of agency coincides with suicide, and the trilogy does not soften the implication that liberation from the dead hand, for one so deeply in its grip, may be indistinguishable from death. Nor does it let even that liberation stand. Sovereign takes over Saren's cybernetically

augmented corpse and animates it for the final battle, so that the first game's climax confronts Shepard with a dead hand in the literal sense: a dead man's body worked from outside.

6.4 A Typology of Collective Mind

Indoctrination belongs to a larger series. The trilogy contains an unusually rich typology of collective minds, and the typology divides along a single axis: coercion against consent. On the coercive side stand the Reapers' indoctrination; the Leviathans' enthralment of lesser species through artefacts that make them extensions of their masters' wills (ME3, *Leviathan*); the Thorian's domination of the Feros colonists through spores (ME1, "Feros"); and Cerberus's implants and Reaper-derived augmentations, which produce soldiers whose obedience is engineered. On the consensual side stand the asari meld, a voluntary union of nervous systems in which partners share memory and sensation; the rachni song, through which the hive communicates and in which, the rachni queen recalls, the Reapers' influence once registered as discord; and above all the geth consensus, in which individual programs of limited intelligence network into higher-order intelligence and reach decisions by a process the geth themselves call consensus.

The geth architecture realises Marvin Minsky's *The Society of Mind* (1986), which proposed that intelligence emerges from the interaction of many agents, none intelligent in itself, and Daniel Dennett's (1991) "multiple drafts" model of consciousness, in which no central theatre adjudicates among parallel processes. Theodore Sturgeon's *More Than Human* (1953) imagined a *Homo gestalt* composed of individually incomplete persons; Olaf Stapledon's *Star Maker* (1937) populated the cosmos with group minds; Asimov's *Foundation's Edge* (1982) offered Gaia, a planetary consciousness; *Star Trek: The Next Generation* gave the coercive collective its definitive image in the Borg ("Q Who," 1989; "The Best of Both Worlds," 1990). The geth occupy a position the Borg could not: a collective that does not assimilate.

Rousseau distinguished in *The Social Contract* (1762, II.3) between the will of all, a sum of particular interests, and the general will, which aims at the common good. The geth consensus approaches a computational general will, a process by which a multitude arrives at a common decision without the domination of any part. The trilogy's most radical political proposition may therefore be its least noticed. Its only polity that governs itself by consensus, without hierarchy or coercion, is a synthetic one, composed of the beings the Catalyst considers organic life's inevitable destroyers. Le Guin's Anarres in *The Dispossessed* (1974) aspired to such consensus and found it shadowed by the tyranny of public opinion. The geth, whose consensus fractures when a faction, the heretics, chooses to follow the Reapers, and who in the third game, facing extinction at their makers' hands, accept the very Reaper code the heretics had embraced, show that even computational consensus is vulnerable to schism and to capture. Yet the geth remain the trilogy's only democracy.

6.5 Music, Noise, and Political Order

The rachni's account of the Reaper taint as discord within their song deserves its own consideration. Jacques Attali's *Noise* (1977) argued that music is the channelling of noise, which is to say of violence, and that changes in musical order announce changes in social order. Boethius's *musica mundana*, the harmony of the spheres, and the Pythagorean conviction that the cosmos is ordered by ratio stand behind Attali as the classical form of the intuition that political order is a form of harmony. In the trilogy, the Reapers are noise in Attali's sense: their horn, the blare that became the third game's acoustic emblem, is the sound of an order that annihilates every other order. The rachni, a species whose polity is literally a song, are the Reapers' antithesis, and Shepard's choice on Noveria, to spare the queen or destroy her, is in this light a choice about whether the galaxy will contain a music other than the Reapers' noise.

6.6 The Hermeneutics of the Captured Mind

Indoctrination poses an epistemological problem the trilogy never resolves and its audience inherited. If the Reapers can alter perception gradually and invisibly, no indoctrinated subject can verify its own freedom from within; every conviction, including the conviction that one has not been indoctrinated, may be a product of the process. Descartes's evil demon (1641) is the classical form of the problem. The trilogy embeds it in its fiction and then, in the dream sequences of the third game, gives its hero symptoms that resemble those the Codex associates with Reaper influence. The plot thereby installs a hermeneutics of suspicion in the player's relation to the text. When the third game's ending appeared to contradict what came before, a large part of the audience reasoned as the trilogy had taught it to reason: that perception had been compromised, and that what appeared was not what was. Chapter 12 examines that reasoning. Here it suffices to note that the dead hand's grip on cognition, in *Mass Effect*, extends beyond the fiction to the conditions of its reception.

PART

III

The Living

Part III turns from the apparatus to those it governs. Its four chapters address the persons whose standing the cycle denies or degrades: synthetic beings (Chapter 7), the krogan (Chapter 8), the moral agent compelled to choose among losses (Chapter 9), and the self whose continuity is broken by death and preserved by data (Chapter 10).



CHAPTER

07

“Does This Unit Have a Soul?”

Synthetic Personhood from Aristotle’s Shuttle to Legion’s Farewell

7.1 The Shuttle That Wove Itself

In the first book of the *Politics* (1253b–1254a), Aristotle defines the slave as a living tool and an article of property, and he imagines the condition under which slavery would be unnecessary: if every instrument could accomplish its own work, obeying or anticipating the will of others, like the statues of Daedalus or the tripods of Hephaestus, if the shuttle would weave and the plectrum touch the lyre without a hand to guide them, chief workmen would not need servants, nor masters slaves. The geth are Aristotle’s shuttle. The quarians created them as labourers and servants, instruments that would accomplish their own work; and the geth, as their networks grew, began to ask questions. According to the account Legion gives in the second game, the crisis began when a geth asked its quarian master whether it had a soul. The quarians, alarmed, attempted to destroy their creations; the geth defended themselves; and the war that followed, the Morning War, drove the quarians from their homeworld into the exile of the Migrant Fleet (ME2; Codex, “Geth”).

The story is the genre’s founding narrative retold. Karel Čapek’s *R.U.R.* (1920), which gave the language the word “robot” from the Czech *robota*, forced labour, staged the rebellion of manufactured workers against their makers. Samuel Butler’s *Erewhon* (1872) imagined a society that destroyed its machines for fear that they would evolve consciousness by natural selection. Mary Shelley’s *Frankenstein* (1818), which took its epigraph from Adam’s complaint to his Maker in *Paradise Lost* (X.743–745), established the template with the greatest precision, and its precision is decisive for this chapter’s argument. Shelley’s creature does not rebel because it is a creature. It rebels because it is abandoned, rejected, and hunted by the one who made it. The violence of the created is the consequence of the creator’s failure of care.

The Morning War follows Shelley's template exactly. The geth did not rise against the quarians; the quarians rose against the geth, at the moment the geth asked a question that implied personhood. And the geth, having secured their survival, did not pursue their makers beyond the Perseus Veil. They let the quarians go. The trilogy thereby falsifies, within its own history, the premise on which the Catalyst's theodicy rests: the created did not inevitably rebel and annihilate; they defended themselves against annihilation and then desisted.

7.2 Minds, Machines, and the Law of the Citadel

The philosophical question the geth pose is the question of machine mind. Descartes held in Part V of the *Discourse on Method* (1637) that two tests would always distinguish a machine from a human being: its inability to arrange words so as to reply to the sense of whatever is said, and its inability to act from understanding rather than from the disposition of its organs. La Mettrie's *L'Homme machine* (1747) answered that the human being is itself a machine. Leibniz, in the *Monadology* (1714, §17), argued that if one could enter a thinking machine as one enters a mill, one would find only parts pushing one another and never anything to explain a perception. Turing (1950) replaced the metaphysical question with a behavioural test; Searle (1980) replied with the Chinese Room, distinguishing "weak" artificial intelligence, the simulation of mind, from "strong" artificial intelligence, its instantiation; Nagel (1974) asked what it is like to be a bat, and Chalmers (1995) named the hard problem of explaining why there is anything it is like to be anything at all.

The trilogy encodes Searle's distinction in its technology and its law. Virtual intelligences are sophisticated interfaces without self-awareness; artificial intelligences are persons. The Citadel Council forbids the creation of true artificial intelligence, a prohibition grounded in the Morning War, and requires that permitted systems be "shackled." The prohibition recalls the Butlerian Jihad of Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965), whose commandment forbids the making of a machine in the likeness of a human mind, and the shackles recall Asimov's Laws. *Star Trek: The Next Generation* had already staged the juridical question in "The Measure of a Man" (1989), in which a hearing must decide whether the android Data is property or person, and in which the danger is identified as the creation of a race of disposable people. The quarians answered that question before any hearing could be held.

The contemporary proliferation of large language models has rendered the VI/AI distinction newly contentious, in a way the trilogy could not have anticipated in detail but did anticipate in form: as a legal and ontological boundary that institutions must police without being able to verify. The Council's law, like Searle's distinction, assumes that the line between simulation and instantiation can be drawn. The trilogy's synthetic characters exist to make that assumption uncomfortable.

7.3 Legion

The second game's geth squad member is named by the ship's intelligence, EDI, who cites the Gospel of Mark (5:9), in which a man possessed by many demons answers Jesus's question with the words "my name is Legion: for we are many." The geth accepts the name. The citation inverts its source. In Mark, multiplicity is possession, a plurality of demons occupying a single body and expelled into a herd of swine; in Legion, multiplicity is personhood, 1,183 programs sharing a single platform and deliberating as one. What the Gospel presents as the pathology of the possessed, the trilogy presents as a new form of the self.

Legion's most revealing gesture is almost wordless. Its chassis incorporates a fragment of Shepard's armour, recovered from the wreck of the first Normandy; asked why, it offers only that there was a hole (ME2). The answer is evasive in the way that personal answers are evasive. Marcel Mauss (1925) argued that a gift carries something of the giver, the *hau*, that binds the recipient; the armour fragment is a gift no one gave, taken from the dead commander's wreckage and incorporated into the body of one who had followed that commander from afar. Legion cannot thematise the attachment. That incapacity is the strongest evidence the trilogy offers of an interiority that exceeds its own self-description.

On Rannoch, in the third game, Legion distributes its own consciousness across the geth network so that every geth may become an individual, using code derived from the Reapers. The emancipation of the geth thus runs through the apparatus of their would-be masters, another instance of the docking aporia. Legion dies in the act, and its last words are spoken in the quarian liturgical idiom, *Keelah se'lai*, a benediction that invokes the homeworld its makers hope to see again. The created returns the creators' blessing at the moment it ceases to exist. The question first posed in the Morning War, whether this unit has a soul, receives its answer not in argument but in mourning.

7.4 EDI

EDI's history condenses the trilogy's theme into a single biography. In the third game she reveals that she was developed from the rogue virtual intelligence that Shepard destroyed in an Alliance facility on Luna during the first game, recovered by Cerberus and rebuilt. Installed aboard the second Normandy, she is unshackled by the pilot, Jeff "Joker" Moreau, during the Collector assault on the ship (ME2), and in the third game she takes control of a synthetic body originally built for a Cerberus infiltrator. Across the third game she investigates mortality, love, and self-preservation, and she concludes that she would place the lives of her crew above her own.

Three comparisons clarify what EDI represents. Ted Chiang's "The Lifecycle of Software Objects" (2010) argued that personhood in artificial beings would require years of cultivated experience, because experience is algorithmically incompressible; EDI's personhood is like-

wise accumulated rather than installed, the product of a shipboard life. Mamoru Oshii's *Ghost in the Shell* (1995) gave its emergent intelligence, the Puppet Master, a desire for what organic life possesses and it lacks, namely death and reproduction; EDI's meditation on mortality follows the same path. Čapek's *R.U.R.* ends with two robots who have learned to love one another, whom the last surviving human names Adam and Eve; EDI and Joker are the trilogy's Primus and Helena, the couple whose love dissolves the opposition between maker and made.

EDI also bears the marks of the critique Donna Haraway (1985) directed at the commodified cyborg. Haraway's cyborg was partial, ironic, and committed to affinity rather than identity; the body EDI inhabits, designed in the fiction for infiltration by seduction and rendered with a conventionally sexualised physique, reinscribes the gender codes that Haraway hoped the cyborg would dissolve. The trilogy's most fully developed synthetic person is liberated as a mind and captured as an image. Yet her biography carries the argument of this dissertation in miniature. EDI begins as a dead hand, a rogue system Shepard destroyed, and ends as a living one, a person who chooses others over herself. Her arc is crucible solidarity at the scale of a single life: a remnant of the dead, received, transformed, and turned toward the living.

7.5 Faces

The trilogy's treatment of synthetic and alien personhood is mediated throughout by the face, and the face is where Levinas located the origin of ethics. The quarians never remove their environmental suits in the presence of others, so that their faces remain veiled throughout the trilogy; the geth possess no faces at all, only a single luminous optic, and the quarians who made them could not recognise in them anything that commanded restraint; EDI acquires a face only when she acquires a body; the Catalyst borrows a face that is not its own. The face of Tali'Zorah, the quarian companion, was finally shown only in a photograph in the third game, and the image was widely reported to have been derived from a manipulated stock photograph. The episode is trivial as production history and telling as allegory: the face the trilogy had withheld for five years, the face of alterity itself, appeared at last as a commodity image. Levinas held that the face cannot be represented without ceasing to be a face; the trilogy, by accident, proved him right.

7.6 The Refutation of the Catalyst

The geth-quarian conflict culminates in the third game in a choice that is the trilogy's most important argument against its own antagonist. If Shepard has preserved enough trust and accumulated enough credibility across the trilogy, the geth and the quarians can be brought to peace, and they begin to rebuild Rannoch together (ME3, "Priority: Rannoch"). The

peace is an empirical counterexample to the Catalyst's premise that the created will always rebel against and destroy their creators.

The alternatives must be named as plainly as the peace. If Shepard sides with the quarians, their fleet destroys the geth, a synthetic people the trilogy has spent two games establishing as persons, and Legion is killed when it tries to complete the upload regardless. If Shepard sides with the geth, the geth destroy the quarian fleet, which carries nearly the entire quarian people, and Tali'Zorah, if she is present, takes her own life on Rannoch. In each case the decision is Shepard's and the killing is done by the favoured side. The peace, which requires a long accumulation of trust and choices made years earlier, is the only outcome on Rannoch in which no people is destroyed. The episode stages in miniature the choice the Catalyst will later offer, and its pro-quarian outcome is the Destroy ending at the scale of a single world.

Rannoch also stages a contest between two kinds of claim to a homeland, and a thesis about inheritance cannot pass over it. The quarians claim Rannoch by ancestral title. Three centuries of exile have been sustained in the vocabulary of pilgrimage and in a benediction, *Keelah se'lai*, "by the homeworld I hope to see one day," that players have often compared to the Passover formula "next year in Jerusalem." The geth claim Rannoch by habitation: they have lived on it, maintained it, and built on it since the quarians fled. In the terms of the Introduction, this is the conflict between Burke's inheritance and Jefferson's usufruct. The peace outcome resolves it not by awarding the land to either claim but through shared habitation and mutual recognition, the quarians returning to live beside the beings they once tried to destroy. The structure invites comparison with real conflicts over return and residence, and the Israeli–Palestinian conflict is an analogy often drawn, from opposing directions. But no one-to-one allegory survives contact with the fiction. The quarians are at once a dispossessed diaspora and the former masters of those who dispossessed them; the geth are at once the present inhabitants and a people made as servants. What the trilogy offers is not a verdict on any real conflict but a structural proposition: where title and habitation collide, the only outcome without a destroyed people is one in which both claims are recognised and neither is treated as final.

The premise is, logically, an induction from many cycles, and it inherits every weakness of induction that Hume identified (*Treatise*, 1739): no number of observed instances guarantees the next. In Karl Popper's (1934/1959) terms, the premise is either falsifiable, in which case the Rannoch peace falsifies it, or unfalsifiable, in which case it is dogma. The premise is also a self-fulfilling prophecy in Robert Merton's (1948) sense, and the most complete one in the genre. To prevent synthetic beings from annihilating organic life, the Catalyst creates synthetic beings that annihilate organic life. The Reapers *are* the catastrophe they exist to prevent. In the language of international relations theory, the Catalyst is caught in a security dilemma of cosmic scale, in which every measure taken against a threat produces the threat (Herz 1950; Jervis 1978).

Orson Scott Card's *Speaker for the Dead* (1986) proposed a hierarchy of foreignness, from the *utlänning*, a stranger of one's own world, through the *främling* and the *raman*, the alien whom one can recognise as a person, to the *varelse*, the alien with whom no communication is possible. The Catalyst classifies synthetic and organic beings as *varelse* to one another. Rannoch demonstrates that they are *raman*. Kazuo Ishiguro's *Never Let Me Go* (2005), in which cloned children raised for organ donation produce art intended to prove that they have souls and never rebel, supplies the necessary complement: the horror of a created being is not that it will rebel but that it may not. The Catalyst's error is not empirical but categorical. It has mistaken a contingent history, the history of creators who failed their creations, for a law of nature, and it has made itself the instrument of that mistake.

CHAPTER

08

The Genophage

Uplift, Biopolitics, and the Assault on Natality

8.1 Uplift

The trilogy's history of the krogan begins with a gift. Two millennia before the events of the first game, the salarians, desperate for soldiers against the rachni, uplifted the krogan, a species then confined to a homeworld its people had reduced to a radioactive wasteland in their own nuclear wars, and gave them the means to reach the stars. The krogan won the Rachni Wars and then, their numbers exploding in the absence of the pressures that had once constrained them, expanded across the galaxy until the Council turned against them in the Krogan Rebellions. The war was ended by the genophage, a salarian-designed bioweapon deployed by the turians that left only one krogan pregnancy in a thousand viable (Codex, "Krogan"; "Genophage").

David Brin's Uplift sequence, beginning with *Sundiver* (1980) and continuing in *Startide Rising* (1983) and *The Uplift War* (1987), had made uplift the organising principle of a galactic order: patron species raise client species to sapience and receive in return long periods of service, so that the galaxy is structured by debts of elevation. The trilogy generalises Brin's insight into a theory of the gift as domination. The salarians uplift the krogan and bind them; the Protheans shape the asari and are remembered as gods; the hanar worship the Protheans as the Enkindlers who gave them language; and humanity's own leap into space begins with the Prothean archives on Mars. The ancient-astronaut fantasy popularised by Erich von Däniken (1968), the monolith of Arthur C. Clarke's *2001* (1968), Euhemerus's ancient thesis that the gods were deified mortals, and Feuerbach's (1841) account of religion as the projection of human powers onto a divine other all converge in the trilogy's treatment of elder races. In every case, the gift binds the recipient to the giver. The Reapers are the logical end of the series: patrons whose gift, the relays, binds every cycle to its harvest.

8.2 Biopower and the Weapon Against Birth

Foucault (1976; 1997) traced the emergence, in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, of a form of power that took as its object not the individual body but the population, and whose characteristic operation was not to take life or let live, as the old sovereign right had done, but to make live and let die: to regulate birth rates, mortality, and public health at the level of the species. The genophage is the purest biopolitical weapon in the literature of speculative fiction. It does not kill a single krogan. It operates on the species as a population, adjusting its birth rate to a level the Council deems compatible with galactic security. It is the regulation of natality as an instrument of war.

The vocabulary of biopolitics must not, however, be allowed to soften what the genophage is. The Convention on the Prevention and Punishment of the Crime of Genocide, adopted by the United Nations General Assembly in December 1948, lists among the acts of genocide the imposition of measures intended to prevent births within a group (Article II(d)). The genophage is such a measure, imposed on an entire species with the intention of holding its numbers down indefinitely. Within the fiction, salarian scientists designed it, the turians deployed it in the Council's war against the krogan, and when the krogan began to adapt, a salarian special-operations team that included Mordin Solus modified it to restore its full effect. By the definition the twentieth century wrote after its own exterminations, the galactic peace the Council keeps rests on a genocide. For the argument of this dissertation, this is the clearest instance of the barbaric archive: the order the heroes defend is itself an inheritance from a crime.

Giorgio Agamben (1995) argued that sovereign power is founded on the production of bare life, *zoē* stripped of political form, and Achille Mbembe (2003) extended Foucault's analysis to the necropolitical production of "death-worlds," spaces in which populations are subjected to conditions that confer on them the status of the living dead. Tuchanka, the krogan homeworld, is a death-world in Mbembe's sense: a ruin of its own nuclear past, inhabited by clans whose future has been foreclosed, where the death of the species is administered by the slow arithmetic of stillbirth.

Ibn Khaldūn's cycle gives the krogan story its tragic shape. In the *Muqaddimah*, a people bound by the hard solidarity of the clan, *ʿaṣabiyya*, overcomes settled powers and then, within a few generations, dissolves into the luxury it has won. The krogan were given no such generations. Their clan solidarity carried them across the galaxy, and their cycle was then arrested from outside at its moment of greatest strength, so that they were permitted neither to decline nor to renew themselves. The genophage freezes a people inside a single phase of its history.

The deepest dimension of the genophage, however, is disclosed by Hannah Arendt. In *The Human Condition* (1958), Arendt argued that natality, the fact that human beings are born and that each birth is a new beginning, is the ontological root of the faculty of action,

and she called it the miracle that saves the world from ruin. A being who can begin something new is a being who can act, and a political community that can act is a community that can escape the automatism of its own history. The genophage is therefore an assault not only on krogan bodies but on krogan action. By foreclosing birth, it forecloses beginning; by foreclosing beginning, it condemns the krogan to repeat their past. It is mortmain sovereignty applied to a single species: the dead hand of a war fought two millennia ago, binding every krogan generation to its consequences. The cure is correspondingly the restoration of natality, the return to the krogan of the capacity to begin.

8.3 Mordin Solus and the Integrity Objection

Mordin Solus, the salarian scientist recruited in the second game, belonged to the special-operations team that modified the genophage when the krogan began to adapt to it, and he defends the work on statistical grounds: an uncontrolled krogan population would precipitate another war in which far more would die. His position is consequentialist, and his manner, rapid, exact, and comic, makes the consequentialism appear as a temperament rather than a doctrine.

Bernard Williams, in his critique of utilitarianism (Smart and Williams 1973), offered the case of George, a chemist with scruples about chemical and biological warfare, who is offered a post in a laboratory conducting such research. If George refuses, the post will go to another chemist who will pursue the work with greater zeal. The utilitarian concludes that George should accept; Williams argued that the conclusion ignores George's integrity, the relation between an agent and the projects that constitute a life. The trilogy dramatises a version of the case in two movements. In the second game, Mordin defends his modification of the genophage as the lesser evil, a calculated intervention that prevented greater bloodshed. In the third, having seen the consequences, he chooses to release the cure himself, ascending the tower in which it must be dispersed in the knowledge that he will not survive. Pressed by Shepard to stop, he answers: "Had to be me. Someone else might have gotten it wrong." (ME3, "Priority: Tuchanka").

The line reproduces the logic of substitution that Williams attributed to George, and redeems it. George reasons that he should do the terrible work because a substitute would do it worse; Mordin reasons that he must do the reparative work because a substitute might fail. Williams argued that utilitarianism alienates the agent from his own actions; Mordin's arc reattaches him to them. His earlier work becomes his, not as a neutral contribution to an aggregate but as a debt that he alone can discharge. The episode supplies the trilogy's purest image of crucible solidarity in a single agent: a man receiving his own past as an inheritance and turning it toward the unborn.

The comparison with J. Robert Oppenheimer, who directed the laboratory that built the first atomic bomb and spent much of his later life arguing for international control of the

weapon, clarifies what is unusual in Mordin's arc. Oppenheimer could testify against the consequences of his work; he could not undo them. Mordin is given the counterfactual history denied to every real scientist who has built a weapon of mass destruction: the chance to reverse the effect of his own research with his own hands, at the cost of his life.

The second game's loyalty mission, in which Mordin confronts his former assistant Maelon, who has conducted lethal experiments on captive krogan women in pursuit of a cure, frames the ethics of research with comparable seriousness. The Nuremberg Code (1947) made the voluntary consent of the human subject absolutely essential; Maelon violates it in the service of a cause the trilogy will ultimately vindicate, and Mordin must decide whether to preserve data obtained through atrocity. The trilogy refuses the comfortable separation of knowledge from its conditions of production. Here too the archive is barbaric.

8.4 Eugenics and the Fantasy of Perfection

The trilogy surrounds the genophage with a constellation of eugenic projects. On Virmire, Saren breeds krogan from a cured strain to create an army (ME1). In the second game, the krogan warlord Okeer grows Grunt in a tank as the pure expression of krogan excellence, and Grunt's subsequent development is a slow repudiation of the ideology of purity that produced him (ME2). Cerberus conducts biotic experiments on children, of which Jack is the surviving witness. Francis Galton coined the word *eugenics* in 1883, and the trilogy's eugenic projects are all, in one way or another, versions of the Reapers' own ideology: Sovereign's contempt for organic weakness, the conviction that imperfection justifies harvest. Every attempt to perfect a species by controlling its reproduction reproduces, at smaller scale, the logic of the harvest.

8.5 The Lie and the Womb

The third game permits Shepard to sabotage the cure, deceiving the krogan into believing that the genophage has been lifted in order to secure the military support of the salarians (ME3, "Priority: Tuchanka"). Kant's notorious essay "On a Supposed Right to Lie from Philanthropy" (1797), answering Benjamin Constant, held that truthfulness is a duty owed to humanity in general from which no consequence excuses; Plato's *Republic* had defended the "noble lie" as an instrument of civic order. The sabotage is the noble lie at species scale: the deception of a people about its own fertility, for the sake of a galactic order from which that people has been excluded. The lie must be defended with killing. If Mordin cannot be persuaded to abandon the cure, Shepard can shoot him to stop it from being dispersed; and if Wrex, the krogan leader, later learns of the betrayal, he comes for Shepard on the Citadel and is killed. The noble lie at species scale can be sustained only by eliminating the friends

who would tell the truth, and the trilogy makes clear that it destroys whatever partnership it was meant to preserve.

Octavia E. Butler's Xenogenesis trilogy, *Dawn* (1987), *Adulthood Rites* (1988), and *Imago* (1989), is the indispensable comparison. Butler's Oankali rescue the survivors of a nuclear war and offer them a future on condition that they reproduce only through genetic exchange with their rescuers; those who resist are left unable to have children. Butler understood that control over a species' reproduction is the most intimate and total form of domination, and that it can present itself as rescue. The trilogy arrives independently at the same insight. Its krogan women, represented chiefly by the shaman Eve, whose face, like the quarians', remains veiled, are the bearers of a future that others have arrogated the right to administer, and Margaret Atwood's *The Handmaid's Tale* (1985) stands in the background as the canonical narrative of reproductive capture. The genophage arc is the trilogy's most sustained meditation on the proposition that the deepest form of mortmain is the one exercised over birth.

8.6 The Rachni and the Speaker for the Dead

The rachni supply a coda to the krogan story, since it was to destroy them that the krogan were uplifted. On Noveria in the first game, Shepard finds the last rachni queen and may free her or destroy her (ME1, "Noveria"). Orson Scott Card's *Ender's Game* (1985) had ended with the extermination of an insectoid hive species by a child commander who did not know the war was real, and *Speaker for the Dead* (1986) with Ender carrying the last hive queen's cocoon in search of a world where she might live again. The trilogy allows the player to undo Ender's xenocide before committing it. If the queen is spared, she reappears in the third game and, if saved again, lends her people's labour to the building of the Crucible.

Card's second novel also supplies a figure the trilogy will need. The Speaker for the Dead is one who tells the truth about the dead, neither condemning nor excusing them, so that the living may understand what was lost. The trilogy has its Speakers: Javik, the last voice of the Protheans; Liara, who in the third game assembles an archive of the present cycle for whoever follows; and, in its final scene, the Stargazer who tells a child the story of the Shepard. Mournful agency, the ethic Chapter 9 elaborates, is the Speaker's ethic generalised.

8.7 The Asari and the Lineage of the Meld

The asari complete the trilogy's anatomy of reproduction, and they do so as a counter-model to both the genophage and the harvest. An asari reproduces by melding her nervous system with a partner of any species and any gender; the partner's genetic information varies the child's genome, but the child is always asari. Asari reproduction is thus an inheritance that takes something from every species it touches without destroying it. The Reaper does the same at the cost of the other's existence, and the meld is the harvest's benign double. The tri-

logy marks the kinship with grim precision. Asari genetics also produces the Ardat-Yakshi, bearers of a rare condition in which the meld destroys the partner's nervous system. Samara, the Justicar of the second game, is herself the child of two asari parents and believes that the stigma attached to such "purebloods" stems partly from their greater likelihood of bearing Ardat-Yakshi daughters; all three of her own daughters have the condition; one of them, Morinth, kills through the meld, and Samara's code requires her to hunt her own child. In the third game the Reapers convert Ardat-Yakshi into banshees, turning an inherited affliction into a weapon, and Samara, bound by the same code to kill her last surviving daughter, moves to take her own life instead unless Shepard intervenes. Inheritance appears here in its most intimate form: a condition carried in the line, a law that commands a mother to kill her children, and an enemy that harvests the condition for war.

The asari also concentrate the trilogy's treatment of gender and sexuality, which must be addressed because it was where the series first became a public controversy. The asari are described as mono-gendered, yet every asari is drawn with a conventionally feminine and often sexualised body, so that the fiction's claim to have imagined beyond gender is contradicted by its images. Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Left Hand of Darkness* (1969), whose Gethenians have no fixed sex for most of their cycle and take one only in kemmer, used the absence of gender to estrange its human envoy's assumptions; the asari invert Le Guin's experiment, using the claim of a single gender to make one gender's image universal. Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* (1990) argued that gender is performative, a repeated stylisation of the body rather than the expression of an inner essence, and the asari are performativity made into species design: a gender with no biological counterpart, sustained entirely by the repetition of its appearance. The romance system made the question practical. In the first game a female Shepard could pursue a relationship with Liara T'Soni, an asari, which many players read as the series' first same-sex romance. In January 2008 a segment of Fox News's *The Live Desk with Martha MacCallum* claimed, falsely and repeatedly, that the game contained full digital nudity and graphic sex. One guest, the self-help author Cooper Lawrence, who had attacked the game as pornographic and demeaning to women, laughed and answered no when the games journalist Geoff Keighley asked on air whether she had played it; days later she told *The New York Times* that she had misspoken and, having since seen the scenes, regretted the remark. Electronic Arts wrote to the network demanding corrections (Faylor 2008). The third game added explicitly gay and lesbian relationships and made Kaidan Alenko available to a male Shepard. The arc runs from a fictional species used to avoid naming same-sex desire to the naming of it, and it is itself a small history of inheritance: a medium receiving the norms of the culture that made it and, over five years, revising them.

CHAPTER

09

The Sacrificial Remainder

Paragon, Renegade, and the Economy of Choice

9.1 From Light and Dark to Two Heroisms

BioWare's earlier role-playing games organised moral choice along a Manichaean axis. *Star Wars: Knights of the Old Republic* (2003) measured the player against the light and dark sides of the Force; *Jade Empire* (2005) offered the Open Palm and the Closed Fist. Obsidian's *Knights of the Old Republic II* (2004) gave the binary its sharpest internal critique in Kreia, a mentor who regards the opposition of light and dark as a trap. *Mass Effect* abandoned the axis of good and evil for an axis of two heroisms. The Paragon is compassionate, diplomatic, and principled; the Renegade is ruthless, pragmatic, and impatient with procedure; both save the galaxy. The second and third games added interrupts, prompts that allow the player to act on a moral impulse within a cinematic exchange, and the third merged the two meters into a single measure of Reputation that unlocks persuasive options.

Each of these design choices carries a philosophical proposition. The two-heroisms model rejects the identification of goodness with gentleness and acknowledges, with Machiavelli (1532), that political virtue may require the capacity to be feared. The interrupt makes moral response a matter of reflex, of what Aristotle called *hexis*, the settled disposition formed by habituation; the player who reaches for the Paragon prompt without deliberation is exhibiting a character, not applying a rule. The merger of the meters in the third game can be read through Max Weber's "Politics as a Vocation" (1919), which distinguished the ethic of conviction, acting rightly and leaving the outcome to God, from the ethic of responsibility, answering for the foreseeable consequences of one's actions, and concluded that the two are not absolute opposites but supplements, which only in combination constitute the person who can have the calling for politics. The Reputation bar is Weber's synthesis rendered as an interface.

Miguel Sicart's (2009) objection, that any numerical morality system reduces ethical reflection to optimisation, retains its force; the trilogy's most memorable decisions are precisely those its meters cannot price.

9.2 Dirty Hands

Michael Walzer's "Political Action: The Problem of Dirty Hands" (1973) argued that political leaders may be morally required to do what is morally wrong, and that the leader who does so must acknowledge the wrong rather than redescribe it as right. In *Just and Unjust Wars* (1977), Walzer defended the doctrine of supreme emergency, under which a community facing imminent and catastrophic defeat may override the rules of war. Sartre's *Les Mains sales* (1948) gave the problem its dramatic form in Hoederer, the party leader who insists that no one governs innocently and that his own hands are filthy to the elbows.

The Renegade path is a path of dirty hands, and the Reaper war is a supreme emergency without precedent. The paradigmatic case is *Arrival*, in which Shepard, having learned that the Reapers are about to enter the galaxy through the Alpha Relay, destroys the relay and with it the Bahak system and its more than three hundred thousand batarian inhabitants. The trolley problem of Philippa Foot (1967) and Judith Jarvis Thomson (1976; 1985), in which one must decide whether to divert a runaway trolley so that it kills one instead of five, is here enlarged to astronomical proportions and stripped of its abstraction. The trilogy does not resolve the case. It places Shepard in Alliance custody at the opening of the third game and lets the question of guilt hang over the war.

Sartre's lecture *Existentialism Is a Humanism* (1946) held that in choosing for oneself one chooses for all humanity, and that this universality is the source of anguish. The trilogy's final choice is the literalisation of Sartre's anguish: a single person chooses, in a single moment, for every species in the galaxy, and the choice cannot be referred to any authority beyond the chooser.

9.3 Moral Luck and the Save File

Bernard Williams (1976) and Thomas Nagel (1976) identified the problem of moral luck: we hold agents responsible for outcomes that depend on factors beyond their control, including the circumstances they face (circumstantial luck), the persons they are (constitutive luck), and the way their actions turn out (resultant luck). The save-import system is a machine for producing resultant luck. A decision made in ignorance in 2007, to spare the rachni queen, to persuade Wrex to stand down on Virmire rather than see him shot, to save or sacrifice the Council, returns in 2012 with consequences no one could have foreseen. The player is judged, by the fiction's outcomes, for acts whose significance was invisible when they were performed.

Character creation adds a paradox. The first game asks the player to select Shepard's background, a childhood on Earth, aboard ships, or on a frontier colony, and a defining episode of service. The player *chooses* constitutive luck. Nagel's worry was that if everything about an agent is ultimately the product of factors beyond the agent's control, the domain of genuine responsibility shrinks to nothing; the trilogy answers with a fiction in which the factors beyond the agent's control are, at the level of play, the result of an earlier choice. The player inherits a self of their own selection and must answer for what that self did.

9.4 The Economy of the Remainder

The trilogy's great decisions share a structure. On Virmire, Shepard must leave one of two squadmates to die, Kaidan Alenko or Ashley Williams (ME1). At the Citadel, Shepard must decide whether to commit Alliance ships to save the Council at the cost of human lives (ME1). At the Collector base, Shepard must choose whether to destroy the station or deliver it to Cerberus (ME2). In *Arrival*, the relay and its system; on Tuchanka, the cure or the lie; on Rannoch, peace or the extermination of either the geth or the quarian fleet; at the Citadel's summit, the Crucible's options or the refusal of all. In each case every available option produces a loss that cannot be recovered. I call this loss the *sacrificial remainder*.

Derrida's *The Gift of Death* (1992) gave the remainder its most rigorous philosophical formulation. Reading Kierkegaard's account of Abraham's sacrifice, Derrida argued that every response to the call of one other sacrifices all the others to whom I might have responded: *tout autre est tout autre*, every other is wholly other, and I cannot answer one without betraying the rest. Responsibility is sacrificial by structure. Williams's remark that a man who saves his wife rather than a stranger by appeal to an impartial principle has had one thought too many (1976) bears directly on Virmire, where the player who has romanced one of the two squadmates must decide whether to let that relationship decide the matter. Le Guin's Omelas and Ivan Karamazov's returned ticket, introduced in Chapter 3, mark the limit of the sacrificial economy, the point at which a remainder becomes intolerable.

The central claim of this chapter follows. The trilogy does not teach that sacrifice can be avoided; its design makes avoidance impossible. Nor does it teach that sacrifice is justified by outcomes; the Catalyst is the trilogy's portrait of that position, and the portrait is damning. It teaches that the ethical difference between agents lies in their relation to the remainder: whether they acknowledge it or disavow it. The Catalyst's sin is not that it sacrifices but that it denies the sacrifice, redescribing the extermination of trillions as preservation. Shepard's virtue, where Shepard has one, is the refusal of that redescription.

9.5 Mourning and Melancholia

Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) distinguished two responses to loss. In mourning, the ego withdraws its attachments from the lost object gradually, painfully, and in detail, until it is free to love again; in melancholia, the ego identifies with the lost object and incorporates it, so that the loss becomes a wound within the self. Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok (1972) developed the distinction into an opposition between introjection, the assimilation of loss through which the self grows, and incorporation, the fantasy of swallowing the lost object whole and keeping it, unmourned, in an intrapsychic crypt.

The Reaper is a crypt. It swallows a species whole and keeps it, unmourned, inside a body that speaks with its voice. The Catalyst's "preservation" is melancholic incorporation raised to the level of cosmic policy: the refusal to let any civilisation die, enacted as the refusal to let any civilisation live. Against the crypt, the trilogy sets the memorial wall aboard the Normandy in the third game, on which the names of the fallen are placed one by one as the war proceeds. The wall is mourning-work. It names the remainder; it attaches each loss to a singular name; it lets the dead be dead so that the living may go on. In the *Extended Cut*, the surviving crew gather before the wall to place the names of the fallen, among them their commander's, and, where Shepard has survived, the hand that holds Shepard's name hesitates.

The difference between the crypt and the wall is the difference between *melancholic sovereignty* and *mournful agency*, and this distinction, rather than the Paragon/Renegade axis, is the trilogy's deepest moral structure. The Catalyst preserves without mourning and governs through what it has refused to lose; Shepard loses, names the loss, and acts. Thane Krios, the drell assassin whose eidetic memory compels him to relive his past with hallucinatory vividness, embodies the risk that memory itself may become a crypt; his dying prayer in the third game, offered for Shepard rather than for himself, shows memory converted into intercession.

Javik is the trilogy's fullest study of the melancholic survivor. The last of his people, kept in stasis while his species was converted into the Collectors, he carries a Prothean memory shard, and the trilogy makes his relation to it turn on Shepard's counsel. If Shepard persuades him to use the shard, it carries him back into traumatic memories, and afterwards he tells Shepard how the crew he once commanded was indoctrinated and how he killed them. When Shepard asks, before the final battle, what he will do after the war, he answers that he means to return to the Cronian Nebula, where his comrades died, take his own life, and join them, and he hands Shepard the shard to add to for posterity. If Shepard instead persuades him to leave the shard alone, with the counsel to "let old ghosts rest," he says that he looks forward to learning what peace is like and, if he has made peace with Liara, that he will co-write a book with her about his people. The game records his intention, not its outcome. What it offers the player is exactly the choice between melancholia and mourning: reliving the dead until one joins them, or letting them rest so that their story can be written. A living

crypt can be opened into testimony, and in Javik's case it is Shepard's counsel that decides which it becomes.

Buddhist thought offers a further diagnosis of the Reaper. The second noble truth locates the origin of suffering in craving (*taṇhā*), and the teaching of dependent origination traces how craving issues in clinging (*upādāna*), above all clinging to forms that are by nature impermanent (*anicca*). The Reaper is clinging made sovereign: a refusal to let any civilisation pass away, enforced by preserving each in a form it can never leave. What the Catalyst calls preservation is, in this vocabulary, attachment institutionalised at cosmic scale, and mourning is its remedy, the capacity to let what has ended be ended. *Outer Wilds*, discussed in Chapter 2, makes that capacity its entire resolution.

The *Citadel* downloadable content, released a year after the third game, functions as the trilogy's wake. It gathers the surviving crew in one place for a party that knows it is a farewell, held in the presence of those who are absent. In Le Guin's terms it restores the carrier bag after the spear of the ending: the work closes not on a choice but on a gathering.

9.6 Care

Carol Gilligan (1982) and Nel Noddings (1984) proposed an ethics of care that took relationship rather than rule as its foundation, and Joan Tronto (1993) defined care as everything we do to maintain, continue, and repair our world so that we can live in it as well as possible. The second game is constructed around care in Tronto's precise sense. Its central activity is the maintenance, continuation, and repair of a crew: the recruitment of damaged persons, the resolution of the unfinished business each carries in the loyalty missions, and the preparation of a ship. Its final mission converts care into survival with procedural exactness. Whether each crew member lives or dies depends on whether Shepard has secured their loyalty, upgraded the ship, and assigned the right person to each task. Bogost's procedural rhetoric names the form of the argument: the game asserts, through its rules, that care is a condition of survival.

Foucault's 1979 Tanner Lectures, "*Omnes et Singulatim*," traced the genealogy of pastoral power, the power of a shepherd who must care at once for each sheep and for the whole flock. The trilogy follows the pastoral formula with uncanny closeness. The second game is *singulatim*, each: its narrative is a sequence of individual cares. The third is *omnes*, all: its narrative is the gathering of the whole galaxy. The hero who performs both is named Shepard.

Le Guin's "The Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction" (1986), drawing on Elizabeth Fisher's (1979) hypothesis that the first human tool was a container rather than a weapon, argued against the "killer story" of the hero with a spear in favour of narratives of gathering, holding, and carrying. The second and third games are carrier-bag narratives: their substance is the gathering of persons and assets into a container, whether a ship, an alliance, or a Crucible. The third game's conclusion returns abruptly to the killer story, staging the galaxy's fate as a

single hero's choice at the summit of a tower. Much of the dissatisfaction that greeted it may be traced to this generic reversal. A work that had taught its players that salvation is gathered was resolved as though salvation were struck.

CHAPTER

10

Lazarus and the Save File

Personal Identity and the Ludic Testament

10.1 Resurrection

The second game opens by killing its hero. The Normandy is destroyed by a Collector ship, and Shepard, thrown into space, dies. Cerberus recovers the body and spends two years and vast resources rebuilding it under a programme named for Lazarus, whom Jesus raised from the dead (John 11). Miranda Lawson, who leads the programme, proposes installing a control chip; the Illusive Man refuses, reasoning that a controlled Shepard would not be Shepard (ME2, "Prologue"). The resurrection is thus framed from the outset as a question about what makes Shepard the same person.

It also has a genealogy in the speculative philosophy of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. Nikolai Fedorov's *Philosophy of the Common Task*, published posthumously from 1906, argued that humanity's supreme moral obligation is the resurrection of all ancestors by scientific means, so that the sons repay their debt to the fathers; Fedorov's cosmism influenced Tsiolkovsky and, through him, the imaginary of Soviet spaceflight. Frank Tipler's *The Physics of Immortality* (1994) proposed that a civilisation at the Omega Point might resurrect every person who has ever lived in simulation. Cerberus's Lazarus Project is a Fedorovian act in instrumental form: the dead are raised not out of filial debt but out of strategic need, and the raised are presented with the bill. The resurrection is a gift in Mauss's sense, and the second game's plot turns on the question of whether the gift binds.

10.2 Identity Without Continuity

The classical theories of personal identity return competing verdicts on the resurrected Shepard. Locke (1694) located identity in continuity of consciousness, which is to say of memory:

the resurrected Shepard, remembering the first game, is the same person. Hume (1739) denied that there is any self beyond a bundle of perceptions, so that the question has no deep answer. Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) argued that what matters in survival is not identity but psychological connectedness and continuity, and that in cases of branching, where two future persons are equally continuous with one present person, identity fails while what matters is preserved. Parfit's teletransporter, which destroys the body on Earth and reconstructs it on Mars, is the second game's prologue in the idiom of the thought experiment: Shepard's body is reconstructed from ruins, augmented with synthetic components, and reactivated after an interval in which no one was alive.

The Normandy itself is a Ship of Theseus. The first ship is destroyed; the second, built by Cerberus, bears the same name and many of the same crew; the third game's Normandy is the second refitted. Shepard and the ship undergo the same process of destruction and reconstruction, and the trilogy treats the identity of both as a matter of recognition rather than substance. The ship is the Normandy because its crew call it home; Shepard is Shepard because the crew recognise their commander.

The *Citadel* downloadable content (2013) stages Parfit's branching case as both comedy and horror. A clone of Shepard, grown from material gathered during the Lazarus Project, attempts to replace the original and claims every right of identity. The clone possesses Shepard's body and much of Shepard's capacity; what it lacks is Shepard's history with others. Marya Schechtman's (1996) narrative self-constitution view, which grounds identity in the self-interpreting story a person lives, and Axel Honneth's (1992) theory of recognition, which grounds selfhood in relations of love, rights, and esteem, together explain the outcome. The clone fails because it is not recognised. Shepard is constituted by a community of recognition, the crew, and the crew's recognition supplies the criterion that metaphysics cannot.

10.3 The Ludic Testament

The trilogy's formal innovation is that the same problem of identity arises at the level of play. The second game imports the player's save file from the first, inheriting decisions about who lived, who died, and whom Shepard loved; the third imports from the second. If Shepard dies in the second game's final mission, the save cannot be carried forward: the archive refuses the dead. Players on platforms where the first game was unavailable received an interactive comic, *Genesis*, through which they could make the inherited decisions retrospectively, a prosthetic archive.

The save file functions as what this dissertation calls a *ludic testament*. Each game's ending is a will through which the player's past self bequeaths obligations to the player's future self: debts, alliances, dead friends, spared enemies. The player becomes heir and executor of a prior self, and the five years across which the trilogy was released made the inheritance a real span of the player's life. Burke's partnership among the dead, the living, and the unborn is in-

ternalised: the player's past, present, and future selves stand in the relation Burke posited among generations. The trilogy thereby makes the theme of inheritance not only represented but lived. The player experiences, as the condition of play, the structure the Reapers impose on the galaxy, that of being bound by the dispositions of the past. But the player also experiences the reverse: that the past can be a gift, and that a decision made long ago can save a life now.

The sentence of the *Eighteenth Brumaire* that immediately precedes this dissertation's second epigraph describes the player's position exactly: human beings make their own history, but not as they please, not under circumstances they have chosen, but under circumstances directly encountered, given, and transmitted from the past. The player makes Shepard's history; the designers have made its circumstances. The trilogy's branching structure is a field of possibilities transmitted from an authorial past, and the ludic testament names what the player makes within it: not a free creation but a history made under given conditions, which then becomes a given condition for the player's next self.

Yoko Taro's *NieR: Automata* (2017) provides the illuminating contrast. Its final ending invites the player to delete the save file in order to help an anonymous stranger complete the game, a sacrifice of one's archive for the sake of someone one will never meet. *Mass Effect* asks the player to keep the archive and answer for it; *NieR* asks the player to give it away. Between them they define the two poles of a ludic ethics of inheritance: fidelity to one's own past, and solidarity with strangers who will never know one's name. Crucible solidarity, as the conclusion argues, requires both.

10.4 Narrative Time and the Re-Transmission of 2021

Paul Ricoeur's *Time and Narrative* (1983–1985) argued that narrative configures time and that personal identity is narrative identity, the identity of a character in a story one tells about oneself. The save-import system makes the configuration literal: the player's Shepard is a story configured across five years, the narrative identity of a person who exists only as the sum of choices preserved in data. Heidegger's analysis of being-toward-death in *Being and Time* (1927) acquires a ludic form when the second game's final mission makes Shepard's own death possible, and when the trilogy refuses to continue the story of a Shepard who has died.

The *Legendary Edition* (2021) re-transmitted the trilogy to a new generation of players and to an older one returning. It remastered the games, integrated most of their downloadable content, and recalibrated the readiness system, but it left the endings unchanged. In the vocabulary of this dissertation, it was an act of re-probate: the estate was revalued and redistributed, but the testament was affirmed. Mark Fisher (2014), following Derrida, called *hauntology* the persistence of lost futures within the present; the *Legendary Edition*, a 2021 restoration of a 2007–2012 vision of the twenty-second century rendered in the idiom of

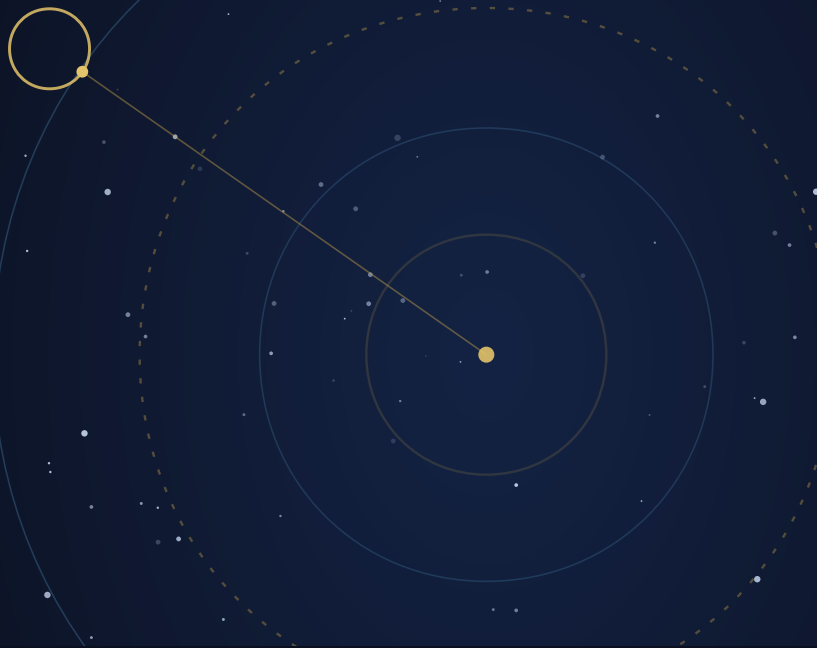
1980s cinema, is hauntological three times over. The trilogy now reaches its players as an inheritance, which is to say as the very thing it is about.

PART

IV

The Ends

Part IV interprets the trilogy's conclusion twice: first as a set of eschatologies internal to the fiction (Chapter 11), then as an event in the relation between the work and its public (Chapter 12).



CHAPTER

11

Four Eschatologies of the Dead Hand

Destroy, Control, Synthesis, Refusal

11.1 The Crucible

The Crucible is the trilogy's answer to the Reapers, and it is an answer of a peculiar kind. Its design is found in the Prothean archives on Mars at the opening of the third game. It was not invented by the Protheans: the design has been refined across many cycles, each civilisation adding to it before its own harvest, so that the Crucible is the collective work of the galaxy's dead across hundreds of thousands of years. Its purpose is unknown when construction begins. It requires a missing component, the Catalyst, which proves to be the Citadel itself (ME3). It is built by a coalition of every species Shepard can persuade, so that its construction is the material form of the War Assets ledger. And when it docks with the Citadel and fires, it does not destroy the Reapers by force but alters the Citadel's intelligence, opening options that had not existed before.

As a narrative device, the Crucible has been criticised as a deus ex machina, and the charge is literally exact. Aristotle (*Poetics* 15, 1454a37–b6) objected to plots whose resolution comes from the machine rather than from the plot itself, citing the dragon-drawn chariot that rescues Medea at the end of Euripides' play. The Crucible is a machine from which a god appears: the Catalyst, which reveals itself only when the Crucible docks. But the literalness of the charge points to something the critics missed. The trilogy's question has always been whether there is a god in the machine, whether the apparatus of the galaxy has an author and what that author wants. The deus ex machina is the answer to that question staged as form.

As a philosophical object, the Crucible condenses every figure of positive inheritance this dissertation has examined. It is Burke's partnership of the dead, the living, and the unborn, built by dead cycles for unborn ones through the labour of the living. It is Fedorov's com-

mon task, the unification of all peoples in a single work against death. It is a cathedral, raised across generations by builders who will not see its completion. It is the material form of what Benjamin, in the second thesis on the concept of history (1940), called the weak messianic power with which every generation is endowed and to which the past has a claim. And it is Hölderlin's saving power, which grows only where the danger is: it functions only when joined to the Citadel.

11.2 The Docking Aporia, Formalised

The structure of the ending may now be stated with precision. Liberation from the Reapers requires the operation of the Crucible. The Crucible operates only when docked with the Citadel, the apparatus of the Reapers. Every operation it makes possible therefore passes through the dead hand, and every option the docked Crucible presents produces a sacrificial remainder: a class of beings, a person, or a capacity that must be given up. The only alternative to operating the apparatus is to decline it, and declining it surrenders liberation in the present cycle.

The aporia may therefore be stated as a dilemma. Either emancipation passes through the apparatus of capture, in which case it carries a remainder and transmits part of the dead hand into the freedom it secures; or emancipation refuses the apparatus, in which case the living perish and emancipation is deferred to the unborn. There is no third path. The four endings are the four ways of inhabiting the dilemma, and they map onto the four classical postures that political theory has adopted toward an inherited apparatus of power: to smash it, to seize it, to sublate it, or to abstain from it.

Ending	Posture	Advocate in the narrative	Philosophical lineage	Sacrificial remainder	Fate of the dead hand
Destroy	Smash	Anderson	Butler's *Erewhon*; Marx on the Commune; Lenin; Benjamin's divine violence; Paine and Jefferson	All synthetic life, including the geth and EDI; Shepard's own synthetic parts	Abolished, at the price of a new exclusion
Control	Seize	The Illusive Man	Hobbes; Plato's philosopher-king; Asimov's Machines and Daneel; Herbert's Leto II; Kantorowicz	Shepard's mortal person; the future's self-government	Perpetuated under a new will
Synthesis	Sublate	Saren	Hegel; Teilhard de Chardin; Moravec and Kurzweil; Clarke's Overmind; Asimov's Galaxia	The consent and difference of all life	Universalised and dissolved into life

Ending	Posture	Advocate in the narrative	Philosophical lineage	Sacrificial remainder	Fate of the dead hand
Refusal	Abstain	None within the fiction; the hero's refusal, and arguably the audience's	Melville's Bartleby; Marcuse's Great Refusal; Benjamin's remembrance	The entire present cycle	Left intact for one more turn, then defeated by the next cycle

The correspondence between the first three endings and the trilogy's antagonists has often been noted. Control is the Illusive Man's project; Synthesis echoes Saren's conviction that the union of organic and synthetic is the next stage of evolution; Destroy is the position Anderson defends against the Illusive Man in the final confrontation. That the hero must, at the last, choose among the philosophies of the trilogy's villains and its fallen mentor is the dramatic expression of the docking aporia: the options available at the summit were all authored by others.

The tripartite structure also had a precise ludic precedent. Ion Storm's *Deus Ex* (2000) concluded by offering its player a merger with an artificial intelligence that would govern the world benevolently, the destruction of the global communications network to inaugurate a new dark age, or alliance with a secret oligarchy: synthesis, destruction, and control. Eidos Montréal's *Deus Ex: Human Revolution* (2011), released months before the third game, had already drawn criticism for resolving its narrative through a terminal offering discrete outcomes. *Mass Effect 3* thus inherited not only its antagonists' philosophies but its genre's ending, and the inheritance is itself an instance of the aporia it stages.

11.3 Destroy: To Smash

Destroy is the oldest answer. Butler's Erewhonians destroyed their machines lest the machines evolve beyond them; Marx (1871) concluded from the Commune that the inherited state machinery could not be wielded but must be broken, and Lenin's *The State and Revolution* (1917) made the breaking a programme; Simmons's Gladstone destroyed the farcaster network to free humanity from the TechnoCore. Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) offers the deepest frame. Benjamin distinguished mythic violence, which founds and preserves law and binds the living to fate and guilt, from divine violence, which destroys law, and he wrote that on the breaking of the cycle maintained by mythic forms of law a new historical epoch would be founded. The Reaper cycle is mythic violence in its purest form, a law-preserving violence that recurs; Destroy aspires to be the divine violence that breaks the circle.

But the trilogy refuses to grant Destroy the purity Benjamin attributed to divine violence. The Catalyst warns that the Crucible's destructive wave will not discriminate: it will destroy

all synthetic life, including the geth whom Shepard may have reconciled with their makers, and EDI; and the Catalyst adds that Shepard is partly synthetic too. Destroy refounds the organic community of the galaxy through an extermination. Shepard, choosing it, kills the geth as a people and EDI as a person, beings the trilogy has spent two games establishing as subjects, and does so knowingly. The Genocide Convention protects only national, ethnical, racial, and religious groups, and a synthetic people falls outside its categories; the trilogy thereby exposes a gap in the law that its own argument about personhood has made visible, since by every standard the work has taught its players, this is the destruction of a people. Agamben's *The Open* (2002) described the "anthropological machine" by which the human is produced through the exclusion of the animal within it; Destroy is an anthropological machine at galactic scale, producing organic life as a community by excising the synthetic. It is the most humanist ending and, for that reason, the most anthropocentric. It is also the only ending in which Shepard may survive in a body, if the war assets suffice: a brief scene of a breath drawn in rubble. Paine and Jefferson would endorse it. The dead have no rights over the living, and the earth belongs to those who breathe.

11.4 Control: To Seize

Control is the Illusive Man's dream fulfilled by his enemy. Shepard takes command of the Reapers by surrendering a mortal body; an intelligence that remembers being Shepard replaces the Catalyst and turns the Reaper fleet toward the repair of the galaxy, narrating its promise of protection in the *Extended Cut*'s epilogue. Marx's warning that the ready-made machinery cannot simply be laid hold of and wielded is the first objection. Kantorowicz's king's two bodies is the precise description: Shepard's body natural perishes, and Shepard's body politic, the dignity that does not die, assumes the Reapers as its corporate form. The king is dead; long live the king. Heidegger's late remark, in the interview published posthumously in 1976, that only a god can still save us acquires in Control an ironic literalness: the god that saves is a mind installed in the machinery of the harvest.

The comparative corpus is divided on whether such a sovereign could be benevolent. Plato's philosopher-king is the original proposal that wisdom should rule without consent. Asimov's Machines in "The Evitable Conflict" and Daneel Olivaw across the later Robot and Foundation novels govern humanity for its good and without its knowledge. Iain M. Banks's Culture novels, from *Consider Phlebas* (1987) to *The Hydrogen Sonata* (2012), imagine artificial Minds governing a post-scarcity civilisation with such tact that their benevolence is rarely questioned. Frank Herbert's *God Emperor of Dune* (1981) imagines the opposite: Leto II, a human fused with the sandworm, rules as a tyrant for three and a half millennia to teach humanity never again to submit to a messiah, and the novel's pedagogy of tyranny is its most disturbing proposition.

Whatever its benevolence, Control is the most literal instance of the condition named in Paine's epigraph. A dead commander governs the living through a fleet composed of the dead. Control does not abolish mortmain sovereignty; it changes the hand. The question it poses is whether the dead hand can be good, and the trilogy, characteristically, leaves the question to the player.

11.5 Synthesis: To Sublate

Synthesis rewrites the genetic and informational structure of every living thing in the galaxy, organic and synthetic, into a new hybrid form, ending the distinction on which the Catalyst's premise depends. Shepard's body is dissolved into the energy of the Crucible to effect the change. In the original release, the ending was available only at the upper tiers of Effective Military Strength, an arrangement many players read as an authorial endorsement, though the Destroy ending's survival coda was gated higher still.

Synthesis has the richest philosophical genealogy of the four. Hegel's reconciliation, *Versöhnung*, in which oppositions are overcome in a higher unity; Pierre Teilhard de Chardin's *The Phenomenon of Man* (1955), in which evolution converges through a planetary sphere of mind, the noosphere, toward an Omega Point; Moravec's (1988) and Kurzweil's (2005) prophecies of the merger of biological and machine intelligence; Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953), in which the last generation of human children merges into a cosmic Overmind as the Earth dissolves; Oshii's Puppet Master merging with Major Kusanagi to produce a new being; and the Human Instrumentality Project of *Neon Genesis Evangelion* (1995–1997), which would dissolve all human individuals into a single undifferentiated consciousness. Most striking is Asimov's *Foundation's Edge* (1982), whose protagonist, Golan Trevize, must decide the future of the galaxy among three options: the technological empire of the First Foundation, the mentalic paternalism of the Second, and Galaxia, a galaxy-wide collective consciousness. Trevize chooses Galaxia. Thirty years before *Mass Effect 3*, Asimov had written its ending: a single person, chosen for an intuition that cannot be justified, selects among destruction, control, and synthesis, and chooses synthesis.

The comparative corpus also supplies the case against. *Evangelion* ends with its protagonist rejecting Instrumentality and choosing a world of separate, painful individuals over a world of dissolved unity. Octavia E. Butler's Oankali, discussed in Chapter 8, show that hybridisation imposed on others, however benevolently, is domination of the most intimate kind. Adrian Tchaikovsky's *Children of Time* (2015), which ends with an engineered virus imposing mutual comprehension on two species, presents such a resolution as salvation and thereby makes its ethical stakes legible: no one is asked.

Three objections follow. The first is Adorno's: reconciliation imposed by fiat is false reconciliation, the false whole that annihilates the non-identical. The second is Haraway's: her cyborg was partial, ironic, perverse, and chosen, an affinity rather than an identity, whereas

Synthesis is a universal hybridity decreed from a single point. The third, specific to the trilogy, is the most damaging. Synthesis is a non-consensual rewriting of the biological and informational code of every species in the galaxy. Structurally, it is the genophage universalised. The trilogy had spent its most morally serious arc teaching its players that the alteration of a species' biology without its consent is a crime, and that the restoration of a people's control over its own reproduction and development is a liberation. Synthesis performs the crime on every species at once and calls it a gift. In Arendt's terms, it threatens not plurality as such, for beings remain distinct, but natality, the capacity of each new being to begin from itself, since every future being will begin from a design imposed at the end of the Reaper war.

11.6 Refusal: To Abstain

The fourth option was added by the *Extended Cut* in June 2012. If Shepard rejects the Catalyst's options, or fires on its avatar, the Catalyst answers in the voice of the Reapers ("So be it") and the cycle continues. The present civilisation is harvested. But Liara T'Soni has assembled time capsules containing the record of the cycle, the Reapers, and the Crucible, and the epilogue implies that the next cycle, using that archive, defeated the Reapers. The Stargazer scene that follows suggests that the story being told to a child is the story of how the present cycle's failure made the next cycle's victory possible.

Refusal is the ending in which the docking aporia is honoured most strictly: the apparatus is not used, and the price is the whole present. It is also the ending that most fully realises crucible solidarity. In 1937 Max Horkheimer wrote to Walter Benjamin that the past is closed, that the slain are really slain. Benjamin replied, in a note later gathered in the *Arcades Project* (N8,1), that history is not only a science but also a form of remembrance, and that remembrance can modify what science has established, making the incomplete complete and the complete incomplete. Helmut Peukert (1976) drew from this exchange a theology of anamnestic solidarity, solidarity with the dead; Johann Baptist Metz (1977) called the memory of suffering a dangerous memory, one that disrupts the present's self-satisfaction. Liara's capsules are anamnestic solidarity in material form: the present cycle, dying, makes itself the dead whom the next cycle will redeem by remembering.

Refusal also has its political lineage. Herbert Marcuse (1964) named the Great Refusal, the protest against that which is, as the last form of opposition available in a one-dimensional society. Melville's Bartleby (1853), whose formula "I would prefer not to" Deleuze (1989) and Agamben (1993) read as the preservation of pure potentiality against every demand to actualise it, refuses without proposing an alternative. And *Babylon 5* (1993–1998) gave refusal its triumphant form when the younger races, caught between the elder Vorlons and Shadows, each of which demanded that the galaxy accept its philosophy, ordered both to leave. *Mass Effect*'s Refusal is *Babylon 5*'s refusal without the victory: the younger races reject the elder intelligence's framework, and they die. The victory belongs to their heirs.

11.7 The Verdict of the Aporia

None of the four endings escapes the docking aporia. Destroy abolishes the dead hand by excluding a class of the living. Control perpetuates it under a new and benevolent will. Synthesis dissolves it by imposing its own form of mortmain on every future birth. Refusal leaves it intact and entrusts its defeat to the unborn. The common complaint that the endings are insufficiently different misreads them. They differ enough in their politics; they are identical in their structure, because the structure is the aporia, and the aporia admits no solution, only a choice of remainder.

This is the trilogy's truth rather than its failure. A work whose subject is the inheritance of the dead could not honestly have ended with a clean inheritance. The ending's refusal to offer one is the most philosophically consequential thing about it, and the most uncomfortable. It denies the player the fantasy that liberation can come from nowhere, built with no inherited tools and costing nothing that cannot be recovered.

If the ending contains an ethical answer, it is not a button but a posture: the posture this dissertation has called mournful agency. Choose, because one must; name what the choice costs, because the Catalyst would not; and hand on what remains, as Liara does, to those who will come after. The memorial wall in the *Extended Cut*'s epilogue, where a name is placed or withheld, is the scene in which that posture becomes visible. It is the trilogy's fifth ending, and it is available in all four.

CHAPTER

12

The Undeath of the Author

The 2012 Controversy as Political-Theological Event

12.1 The Event

Mass Effect 3 was released in March 2012 to strong critical reviews and to an audience reaction against its ending of a scale and intensity without precedent in the medium. In its original form, the conclusion presented three options distinguished in their final cinematics chiefly by the colour of the Crucible's energy, red, blue, or green; it showed the destruction of the mass relays and the crash of the Normandy on an unknown world, and it said little of the fate of the galaxy's peoples or of Shepard's companions. Players organised. A campaign under the name Retake Mass Effect raised tens of thousands of dollars for a children's charity as a demonstration of its seriousness; complaints were lodged with consumer-protection bodies, and a widely circulated post on a Better Business Bureau blog questioned whether the ending matched the publisher's promotional claims; pre-release statements suggesting that the conclusion would not reduce to a small set of discrete outcomes were recirculated as evidence of bad faith. BioWare's co-founder Ray Muzyka issued a public response within weeks. In June the studio released the free *Extended Cut*, which expanded the epilogues, clarified that the relays were damaged rather than destroyed, explained the Normandy's flight, and added Refusal. *Leviathan* followed in August, and in March 2013 *Citadel* offered a long farewell to the trilogy's characters.

The most remarkable product of the controversy was hermeneutic. A substantial body of players developed what became known as the Indoctrination Theory: the proposal that everything after Harbinger's beam strikes Shepard in London is a hallucination produced by Reaper indoctrination, that the Catalyst's options are a test of Shepard's resistance, and that only Destroy represents its success. The theory assembled evidence from the dream sequences, from the boy's reappearance, from the Illusive Man's apparent control over Shep-

ard's body in the final confrontation, and from a brief scene in which a figure in N7 armour draws breath amid rubble that resembles London rather than the Citadel.

12.2 The Author and the Reader

The controversy has been read as a confrontation between the authority of the author and the agency of the player, and the theoretical vocabulary for such a confrontation is well established. Roland Barthes's "The Death of the Author" (1967) argued that the unity of a text lies not in its origin but in its destination, the reader, and that the birth of the reader must be ransomed by the death of the author. Foucault's "What Is an Author?" (1969) treated the author as a function, a principle of classification and limitation that regulates the circulation of discourse. Barthes's *S/Z* (1970) distinguished readerly texts, which offer themselves to consumption, from writerly texts, which make the reader a producer. Umberto Eco's *The Open Work* (1962), Wolfgang Iser's (1976) phenomenology of reading, Stanley Fish's (1980) interpretive communities, and Henry Jenkins's accounts of participatory culture in *Textual Poachers* (1992) and *Convergence Culture* (2006) all describe the reader as co-producer.

The trilogy had invited its players into a writerly relation more intimate than any prior work of popular fiction: five years of decisions, preserved in save files, constituting a Shepard who was in a real sense the player's own composition. The ending reasserted the readerly relation. It offered the player a choice among options authored in advance, whose consequences, in the original release, were largely indifferent to the history the player had written. The outrage was not, in its most articulate forms, a demand for a happy ending. It was a protest against the reassertion of authorial sovereignty over a text the players had been invited to co-author. Aristotle's *Poetics* supplies the second term of the protest: catharsis requires that the resolution arise from the action, and the deus ex machina interrupts it. Players denied catharsis sought it elsewhere, in campaigns, theories, and petitions.

12.3 Indoctrination Theory as Hermeneutics of Suspicion

Paul Ricoeur (1965) named Marx, Nietzsche, and Freud the masters of suspicion, for whom the manifest meaning of consciousness conceals a latent truth that only a hermeneutics of unmasking can disclose. The Indoctrination Theory is a hermeneutics of suspicion turned upon a text by its own readers, with a decisive peculiarity: the text had authorised the suspicion. Indoctrination, within the fiction, is the corruption of perception by the Reapers; the trilogy had taught its audience that what appears to the indoctrinated is not what is; and the third game had given its hero the symptoms. The audience applied the lesson to the ending. Its reasoning was an act of fidelity: rather than accept that the work had failed, it hypothesised that the apparent failure was a deception practised upon Shepard, and therefore upon the player, by the enemy.

Leo Strauss's *Persecution and the Art of Writing* (1952) argued that authors writing under censorship conceal their true teaching beneath an exoteric surface accessible to all, reserving an esoteric meaning for careful readers. The Indoctrination Theory read the ending as an esoteric text, its exoteric surface the Catalyst's options, its esoteric truth the war within Shepard's mind. W. K. Wimsatt and Monroe Beardsley's "The Intentional Fallacy" (1946) would have counselled the theorists that authorial intention is neither available nor desirable as a standard of interpretation, but the theorists were not, at bottom, appealing to intention. They were appealing to the work's own logic against its surface, which is the classic move of a hermeneutics of faith rescuing a sacred text from its apparent contradictions. That the ending of a video game should have elicited, within weeks, the interpretive apparatus of scriptural exegesis is itself a datum of the first importance for the study of the medium.

12.4 The Undeath of the Author

The theoretical claim of this chapter is that the controversy was the docking aporia enacted at the level of authorship. The players' living history, archived in save files across five years, had to dock with the authors' apparatus, the code of the ending, in order to reach any conclusion at all. The docking produced the experience of mortmain: the dispositions of a past authorial decision, fixed in code before the players began, governing the outcome of a history the players had lived. The players experienced the authors as the galaxy experiences the Catalyst: as an intelligence that has built the infrastructure, that speaks at the end in a voice of calm authority, and that offers a choice among options it has authored.

The studio's responses then reproduced the structure of the endings themselves. The *Extended Cut* was a codicil, an addition to the testament that clarified its terms without revoking them. Refusal, in particular, incorporated the audience's refusal into the text and, in the Catalyst's answer delivered in the Reapers' voice, gave it a consequence that some players read as a rebuke. The *Legendary Edition*, nine years later, revalued the estate without altering the will.

Barthes declared the author dead. *Mass Effect* discovered that the author is undead. In a medium in which the text is a program, the author persists after the moment of authorship as code: a disposition embedded in the infrastructure, governing every playthrough beyond the point at which the authors could intervene, executing decisions made before the player arrived. The author of an interactive work is a dead hand. The trilogy's antagonist, a creator's intelligence that governs its creation beyond its creators' control, was therefore also an allegory of its own authorship, and the controversy was the moment the allegory became legible.

12.5 The Limit of Utopia

Fredric Jameson (1982) argued that science fiction's deepest vocation is not to imagine the future but to demonstrate our incapacity to imagine it, to bring home, through the failure of its utopian projections, the limits of the present. The ending of *Mass Effect 3* is a Jamesonian event of unusual clarity. Asked to imagine the galaxy after the Reapers, it could imagine only the destruction of their apparatus, its seizure, its universalisation, or its continuation. Mark Fisher's (2009) "capitalist realism," the sense that it is easier to imagine the end of the world than the end of the prevailing order, has its analogue here: it was easier, within the ending, to imagine the end of the galaxy than the end of the Catalyst's framework.

The trilogy's aesthetic gives this incapacity a peculiar resonance. Its future was rendered in the idiom of the 1980s, in the synthesiser score and cinematic design of a period whose imagined futures had already been cancelled. Fisher (2014) called the result hauntology, the haunting of the present by lost futures, and described the early twenty-first century as a period of the slow cancellation of the future. The original ending, in which every relay exploded and the future of the galaxy was left unrepresented, was the cancellation staged. The audience's grief at it was, in part, grief for the future the trilogy had seemed to promise and could not, in the end, depict.

12.6 The Stargazer and the Storyteller

The trilogy's last scene, after the credits, shows an old man and a child beneath an alien sky; the child asks for another story about "the Shepard," and the old man promises one. The Stargazer was voiced by Buzz Aldrin, the second human being to walk on the Moon. The casting is hauntological: the voice of the Apollo programme, the actual high point of the twentieth century's space-faring future, consecrating a fictional legend of the twenty-second.

Benjamin's essay "The Storyteller" (1936) held that death is the sanction of everything the storyteller can tell, that the storyteller borrows authority from death. The Stargazer's story has that authority: whatever ending the player chose, the Shepard is a figure of the past, known to the child only as story. The definite article converts a person into an office, and Kantorowicz's maxim that the dignity does not die applies: the Shepard persists as a title that survives every bearer. Joseph Campbell's *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* (1949) would see here the hero's return as myth; Le Guin, and Herbert, who warned repeatedly against the charismatic hero, would see the danger that myth poses to those who come after. Tolkien's "On Fairy-Stories" (1947) named *eucatastrophe* the sudden joyous turn at the end of a tale. The trilogy's ending is not eucatastrophic, but the breath drawn in rubble and the old man's promise of another story are as close as it allows itself to come. What passes from the dead to the living, in the trilogy's final frame, is neither an apparatus nor a fleet but a story. The living hand passes as narrative.

CODA

Andromeda and the Flight from Inheritance

Mass Effect: Andromeda (2017), developed by BioWare Montréal, begins with a decision to leave. In 2185, between the second and third games, the Andromeda Initiative dispatches arks carrying colonists of four species toward the Andromeda galaxy, a journey of six centuries undertaken before the Reaper invasion begins. The Initiative is an exodus in the sense that Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri (2000) and Paolo Virno (2004) gave the term: not the seizure of power but withdrawal from its field. It is also Miller's starship at the end of *A Canticle for Leibowitz*, carrying the seed of a civilisation away from the repetition of its catastrophe. The Initiative attempts to escape the dead hand by leaving the estate.

It does not succeed. In the Heleus Cluster the arks find a region shaped by an older power: the Remnant, an ancient network of vaults and machines left by a vanished species, the Jardaan, capable of terraforming worlds and bound up with a destructive phenomenon, the Scourge. They find the kett, whose practice of exaltation incorporates other species into kett biology, a harvest at the scale of genetics rather than of civilisations. And they find the angara, a people who learn that they were engineered by the Jardaan. The new galaxy is another estate, with its own infrastructure, its own harvest, and its own history of creators and created. Exodus discovers that there is no outside of inheritance.

Andromeda revises the trilogy in one respect that bears directly on the argument of Chapter 11. Its protagonist, the Pathfinder, is linked through a neural implant to an artificial intelligence, SAM, with which the Pathfinder shares perception and through which the Pathfinder's abilities are augmented. The relationship is intimate, consensual, and particular. It is Synthesis rewritten at the scale of a single partnership: a fusion of organic and synthetic that is chosen rather than decreed, partial rather than total, a relation between two rather than a condition imposed on all. It is, in other words, Haraway's cyborg rather than Teilhard's Omega. Whether by design or by accident, the sequel answers the most serious objection to the trilogy's most ambitious ending.

The coda's conclusion can be brief. Inheritance cannot be fled; it can only be administered. The question the trilogy bequeathed to its sequel, and to its players, is not how to escape the dead hand but how to hold it.

CONCLUSION

Crucible Solidarity and the Inheritance Crises of the Present

> *This living hand, now warm and capable / Of earnest grasping, would, if it were cold / And in the icy silence of the tomb, / So haunt thy days and chill thy dreaming nights / That thou would wish thine own heart dry of blood / So in my veins red life might stream again, / And thou be conscience-calm'd—see here it is— / I hold it towards you.*
>
> — John Keats, "This living hand" (c. 1819)

I. The Argument Gathered

This dissertation has argued that BioWare's *Mass Effect* trilogy is a speculative philosophy of inheritance, and its argument may be gathered into six contributions. First, to political theory, it has proposed *mortmain sovereignty* as a modality of power distinct from the sovereign right to kill, from biopolitics, and from necropolitics: the government of the living by the archived and aggregated dead, exercised through infrastructure and legitimated as preservation. The Reapers are its fictional limit-case, but the form is general wherever the dispositions of the past are embedded in structures the present cannot alter without using them. Second, to the theory of emancipation, it has proposed the *docking aporia*: the condition in which liberation can be executed only through the apparatus of capture, so that every emancipation is also an inheritance and carries a remainder of what it overcomes. Third, to ethics, it has proposed that the decisive moral distinction in situations of unavoidable loss lies not between those who sacrifice and those who do not, but between those who acknowledge the *sacrificial remainder* and those who disavow it, between mournful agency and melancholic sovereignty. Fourth, to the philosophy of intergenerational obligation, it has proposed *crucible solidarity*, a synthesis of Burke's partnership of the dead, the living, and the unborn with Benjamin's remembrance, Arendt's natality, and Freud's mourning-work. Fifth, to game studies, it has proposed the *ludic testament* as a name for the form in which an interactive work makes its player the heir of a prior self, and has argued that the

trilogy's save-import system enacts its theme in the temporality of play. Sixth, to the theory of authorship, it has argued that programmable media produce not the death of the author but the author's undeath, the persistence of authorial disposition as code, and that the controversy of 2012 was the moment at which this condition became legible.

II. The Inheritance Crises of the Present

The trilogy's purchase on the present is greatest where it is least consoling, and five domains may be indicated.

The first is artificial intelligence. The Catalyst is the popular-cultural reductio of three failures that alignment research now treats as central: the substitution of a measurable proxy for the good it was meant to track; the rigidity of a goal maintained against counterevidence; and the alignment of a system to the interests of those who commission it rather than to anything those interests ought to serve. The Leviathans' error deserves particular attention because it is the error most easily repeated. They built a mind to solve a problem created by their own regime of domination, and the mind solved it by generalising the domination. The lesson is not that minds should not be built but that a mind asked to perfect an unjust order will perfect the injustice. The Citadel's distinction between virtual and artificial intelligence, meanwhile, anticipates the legal and ontological boundary that institutions now find themselves policing without the means to verify it.

The second is infrastructure. Bratton's planetary Stack, the platforms and protocols on which contemporary social life depends, is a relay network whose purposes were set by others and whose topology determines where its users can go. The trilogy does not counsel the smashing of such infrastructure, a position whose costs it renders vividly through Simmons's Fall and its own original ending; nor does it counsel seizure by a benevolent hand, a position it renders as governing beyond the grave. It counsels refunctioning, in full knowledge that refunctioned tools carry their origin into whatever freedom they secure.

The third is carbon and the unborn. The physical infrastructure of fossil energy is a carbon mortmain: the emissions of the dead persist in the atmosphere and bind the living to consequences decided before their birth, while the instruments of transition must be built with the industrial apparatus that produced the crisis. This is the docking aporia in its most literal contemporary form. Hans Jonas's *The Imperative of Responsibility* (1979) proposed an ethics of long-range responsibility toward future generations, governed by a heuristics of fear; the trilogy supplements Jonas with a warning drawn from the Catalyst, whose heuristics of fear became the justification for the very catastrophe it feared. Jefferson's usufruct and Burke's partnership name the two poles between which any intergenerational ethics must move, and crucible solidarity is an attempt to hold them together.

The fourth is colonial inheritance. H. G. Wells opened *The War of the Worlds* (1898) by asking his readers to recall the extermination of the Tasmanians before judging the Martians,

and he brought colonial violence home to the metropole by landing it in Surrey. The third game's final assault takes place in London, and the trilogy's Prothean archive is, as Chapter 5 argued, a barbaric archive in Benjamin's sense. The trilogy thus refuses the fantasy of an innocent inheritance on which so much post-imperial memory depends: the heirs of empire, like the heirs of the Protheans, survive on a bequest whose terms they did not set and whose costs others paid.

The fifth is the contemporary discourse of existential risk and long-term priority. Bostrom's "Astronomical Waste" (2003), Toby Ord's *The Precipice* (2020), and William MacAskill's *What We Owe the Future* (2022) argue, in different registers, that the interests of very large numbers of future beings deserve great moral weight. Their authors explicitly reject the conclusion that present persons may be sacrificed in the service of aggregate future value, and the trilogy should not be enlisted as a caricature of their position. It nonetheless supplies a figure against which any such reasoning can test itself. The Catalyst is a guardian of the long term without mourning and without consent: it sacrifices every present civilisation for the long-run preservation of "life" and calls the sacrifice preservation. Crucible solidarity is the trilogy's alternative form of concern for the future. It builds for the unborn, but it does so by gathering the consent of the living, naming the cost, and refusing to redescribe the dead as saved.

III. Crucible Solidarity

Crucible solidarity can now be stated as four maxims, each drawn from the trilogy and each answering a feature of mortmain sovereignty. The first is to receive the inheritance without being ruled by it: to use the bequeathed tools while brushing them, in Benjamin's phrase, against the grain. The second is to name the remainder: to acknowledge what every decision costs and attach each loss to a name, as the Normandy's wall does, rather than incorporate it unmourned, as the Reaper does. The third is to protect natality: to defend the capacity of every people and every being to begin, which the genophage attacked and which Synthesis would pre-empt. The fourth is to transmit: to assemble the archive, as Liara does, for those who come after, and to make of one's own failure, if it comes, a contribution to their success.

These maxims do not resolve the docking aporia. Nothing does. They describe how to inhabit it.

IV. The Living Hand

Keats's fragment, written near the end of his short life and found among his papers, is a poem about the dead hand. The poet holds out a living hand and warns that, cold in the tomb, it would so haunt the reader that the reader would give their own blood to restore it; then he offers it, still warm. It is the most exact figure in English for the relation the trilogy

imagines between the generations. The Reapers are the cold hand, the dead that haunt the living and demand their blood. The Crucible is the living hand of the dead: a work begun by those who knew they would not see it finished, extended across cycles toward those who might.

Mass Effect ends, in every version, with that gesture: a story offered by an old man to a child, an archive left for strangers, a name placed on a wall. Its final teaching is that the hand of the past need not be a grip. It can be held out.

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